Saturday, January 13, 2024
Poush 28, 2080 | Nepal Sambat 1144 | Pohelaathwo Dwitiya

NATION'S 1ST ENGLISH BROADSHEET

risingnepaldaily.com
Vol. LIX, No. 28 | Pages 8 | Rs. 5 | National Edition

THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL

PRESIDENT DRAWS ATTENTION OF TOP LEADERS ON CONTEMPORARY ISSUES

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 12

President Ramchandra Paudel has drawn the attention of the top leaders of three major political parties to work together to consolidate the democratic system by addressing burning problems facing the country.

The President drew attention of top leaders, including Prime Minister and CPN (Maoist Centre) Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda', main opposition party CPN-UML Chairperson KP Sharma Oli and Nepali Congress (NC) President Sher Bahadur Deuba towards implementing federalism, improving governance and reforming the oldest university, informed President's press advisor Kiran Pokharel.

Pokharel further shared that President Paudel had cautioned political parties' leaders to immediately bring laws to grant authority to the province for implementing federalism and maintain good governance to deliver justice to the needy persons.

Also on the occasion, President Paudel drew the attention of leaders to tap the opportunity to initiate reforms at Tribhuvan University by appointing a competent Vice-chancellor. Leaders took the President's move on a positive note, it is said.

NATIONAL UNITY DAY MARKED

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 12

The 302nd Prithvi Jayanti and the National Unity Day were marked across the country on Friday by organising various programmes.

In Kathmandu, President Ramchandra Paudel laid the wreath on the statute of Prithvi Narayan Shah standing in front of the western gate of Singha Durbar in the morning.

Likewise, Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda', former Prime Ministers Sher Bahadur Deuba and KP Sharma Oli, Speaker Dev Raj Ghimire and others also offered a garland to a picture of late King Prithvi Narayan Shah at Bhrikutimandap while attending a tea reception hosted by the Rastriya Prajatantra Party (RPP) on the occasion.

King Prithvi Narayan Shah founded present-day Nepal by unifying small scattered principalities through a unification campaign launched in 1743. So, Prithvi Jayanti is marked every year in honour of the nation-builder. The government has started giving a public holiday on the occasion since last year.

While Prime Minister Prachanda, Speaker Ghimire, former Prime Ministers Deuba and Oli along with other leaders offered garlands to the picture of King Prithvi Narayan Shah placed in Bhrikutimandap, Kathmandu,

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PHOTO: SUJAN GURUNG/TRN

President Ramchandra Paudel paying tribute to late Prithvi Narayan Shah on the occasion of the 302nd Prithavi Jayanti and National Unity Day in front of Singha Durbar in Kathmandu on Friday.

Cold wave affects life across Tarai

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Nepalgunj, Dhanusa, Jan. 12



The excessively cold weather over the past few days has affected the daily lives of people residing in the Tarai belt, including Banke and Dhanusha districts. Children, senior citizens and people from impoverished communities are hardest hit by the ongoing cold waves.

Movement of vehicles and people has been reduced significantly during morning and evening hours in villages and towns of Tarai. Likewise, the number of service seekers in government offices has fallen significantly, and most of the schools are closed.

According to our Nepalgunj correspondent Siraj Khan, the weather has become extremely cold due to the cold wave in Banke district for a few days. The lives of people in this region have turned chaotic owing to the cold waves.

The main markets in Nepalgunj, including Tribhuvan Chowk, Sadarline, Gharbaritole, VP Chowk, Birendra Chowk, and Pushpalal Chowk, have experienced a decline in day-to-day activities.

Those most affected by the cold include rickshaw pullers, cart drivers, and labourers. Furthermore, the extreme cold has had a significant impact on children and the elderly.

As the cold is increasing, the District Disaster Management Committee

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133 Nepali families request govt to bring back their kin from Russian Army

Russia says 10 Nepalis dead so far: Minister Saud



BY PUSHKAR BHANDARI
Dadeldhura, Jan. 12

About 133 families have requested the government to bring back their family members who were recruited into the Russian Army, of which some were injured and some are dead.

"We are trying to bring back the Nepali citizens from Russia and put our diplomatic efforts into practice," Minister for Foreign AffairsNP Saud said at an interaction organised by Nepal Press Union in Amargadhi on Friday.

He said that anyone who had gone to Russia had gone without the approval of the government. Nepali citizens have reached there either on student or visit visas. "So far, the Russian government has informed that 10 Nepalis have died in the conflict. Except for two, eight bodies are kept in the mortuary there. We are making diplomatic efforts to bring the bodies in Nepal," said FM Saud.

He also said that the Nepal government has a clear policy not to send troops to the countries with which Nepal has not inked out military agreements.

Likewise, the Foreign Minister informed that an initiative has been taken for the release of Bipin Joshi, a Nepali student who is in the captivity of HAMAS – a Palestinian rebel group – since it launched the attack in Israel about three months ago. He expressed confidence that Joshi would be released in the second ceasefire.

Stating that 182 people, including Bipin, from different countries, are under the control of HAMAS, FM Saud said that he believed that a two-state solution was applied to solve the problems in the Middle East.

"We have made diplomatic efforts. We have talked to the International Committee of the Red Cross, and the Qatar government which brokering peace between Palestine and Israel. They have informed that they are trying for a ceasefire. I have full confidence that Bipin will be released in the coming ceasefire," he said.

Joint group to resolve boundary issues

FM Saud informed that a Joint Boundary Working Group including the representatives of Nepal and India is working to resolve the border dispute. Apart from Kalapani, Limpiyadhura, Lipulek and Susta, many agreements have been reached.

According to him, during the previous border mapping and delineation, some Nepali territory has gone to the Indian side and Indian land has come to the Nepali side. The work of the Joint Boundary Working Group is progressing with the consent of both the governments, he said.

He also said that the government of Nepal was fully aware of its borders and the land, and efforts were being made to solve the border problem through negotiations, discussions and diplomatic initiatives.

FM Saud also maintained that it is Nepal's policy to finalise the work through the Joint Border Working Group regarding the boundary.

Investment will be attracted in hydro projects

Likewise, Minister Saud said that the recent agreement with India to export about 10,000 Megawatt electricity from Nepal to India in 10 years will help attract more investment in the hydroelectricity sector.

"After its benefits are assured to customers, investment in hydroelectricity projects development and energy generation will increase. World Bank, Asian Bank or international entrepreneurs will be attracted," he said while adding that an agreement to sell 500 MW of electricity has also been advanced with Bangladesh.

Informing that Arun III Hydroelectricity Project is progressing at a fast pace, he said that if West Seti and Upper Karnali hydroelectricity projects could be advanced, more employment would be generated in the country which might reduce the outflow of Nepali youth.

Similarly, he stated that the government has performed well in terms of advancing development projects, implementing reforms in governance, and improving foreign relations.

"On the one hand, we are on the way to concluding the peace process as soon as possible and on the other hand, we are trying to move forward by fulfilling the development wishes of the people by bringing the economy back on track from the deteriorating state," said FM Saud.

Mentioning that Nepal is now under environmental risk, he said that powerful industrialised countries are emitting carbon as they are increasing production to strengthen their economy.

"Due to the impact of the climate change caused by carbon emission and global warming, the sea level is rising while rivers that provide water to one and a half billion people in the South Asian region are also at risk. We are being punished for what we are not doing," said FM Saud.

He said that Nepal showed the impacts of climate change in the mountains to the Secretary General of the United Nations, Antonio Guterres which contributed to increasing awareness about climate change globally.

Nepal's UN envoy elected to head WTO committee

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 12



Ram Prasad Subedi

Ram Prasad Subedi, Ambassador and Permanent Representative of Nepal to the United Nations Office and other International Organisations in Geneva has been elected unanimously as the Chairperson of the Committee on Trade and Development (CTD) of the World Trade Organisation (WTO).

He is elected to the post for a one-year term, informed the Permanent Mission of Nepal in Geneva in a statement on Friday.

In the General Council meeting, Chairperson Ambassador Athaliah Lesiba Molokomme proposed Subedi's name to elect to the post of Chairperson of the CTD together with the names of the candidates for the other WTO bodies where WTO Members unanimously supported her proposal this morning.

According to Nepal's Mission, Nepal has been elected for the position of Chairperson of any Tier-one level body in the WTO for the first time since the country's accession to the WTO in 2004.

Furthermore, Subedi's appointment to the post is a matter of pride for Nepal as it happens to be the 20th anniversary of its accession to the WTO, read the statement.

Ambassador Subedi will take up his new role as the Chairperson of the

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Pet walkers now face KMC fine

BY SUSHMA MAHARJAN
Kathmandu, Jan. 12



Pet walkers in the city have now become aware while taking their pets for walks after the Kathmandu Metropolitan City (KMC) prohibited pets in public places.

Some dog owners walking across the streets in Dallu of KMC Ward No. 15 on Friday morning were seen carrying plastic bags in their hands.

Bikash Shrestha, a local walking his two dogs, expressed frustration over his pets being bound to the house. He said, "One of my dogs is five years old and the other three. I have been taking them for walks since their childhood to release themselves. But, suddenly there is a new rule in the city and it's difficult to tame dogs accordingly. However, I appreciate the steps taken by the local governments and urge them to provide space for the disposal of animal faeces because it is difficult to carry it back home."

Shanti Ghale, who runs a vegetable stall in the locality, expressed happiness over pet owners cleaning up after their animals. She shared the daily struggle of cleaning the street space for her vegetable display, which sometimes included animal and human waste. She said, "I am very happy that now pet owners need to clean the faeces of their animals. Dusting the area is manageable but dealing with faeces is unpleasant, especially with no nearby water source.

Kathmandu Metropolitan City (KMC) has launched a drive to ensure the safety of pedestrians from pet animal attacks and to hold pet owners accountable for their pets from Tuesday. Following it, the metropolis has started taking action against those allowing their house dogs and cats to litter in public places within the Kathmandu metropolitan area.

Dr. Awadesh Jha, head of the Agriculture and Animal Husbandry Department, said that since the launch of the campaign four-five dogs littering in public places were caught and taken to the KMC office in Kathmandu Plazza. Later, they were handed to their owners with consultation not to repeat such activities again. So far, no denizens have been imposed a fine as the campaign was launched to make the public responsible for their house animal activities instead of charging fines, he added.

He said that in accordance with the Kathmandu Metropolitan Dog/Cat Sterilisation, Vaccination and Documentation Working Procedure, 2023, the metropolis has urged pet owners to be responsible for their pets prohibiting house pets from defecating in public spaces and someone else's yards. Stating that exposure to animal faeces could affect human health, he said that the campaign was launched to make the city clean and healthy.

Dr. Jha said, "Prohibiting pet animals from littering in public does not mean that they are not allowed to take walks in public. Pets are permitted to take walks, but pet owners must control their pets and manage their excretion."

He added that the metropolis was also working to install bins in public areas for the disposal of animal faces.

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3.2% GDP growth estimated in 1st quarter

BY LAXMAN KAFLE
Kathmandu, Jan. 12

The National Statistics Office (NSO) has made a preliminary estimation of 3.2 per cent growth in the gross domestic product at the basic price in the first quarter of the current fiscal year 2023/24.

In the seasonally unadjusted quarterly GDP report made public on Thursday, the NSO has estimated an increase of 3.2 per cent in gross domestic product in the first quarter of the current fiscal year as compared to the first quarter of the previous fiscal year. As per the estimation of the NSO, the total value of mining and quarrying will increase by 15.8 per cent in the first quarter of the current fiscal year as compared to the corresponding period last year.

While the total value addition of sand, gravel and stone excavation, which is directly related to the construction sector, is relatively low, the projected increase of 11.4 per cent in the construction sector will have a greater impact on the production of this sector, said the report.

Similarly, the value addition of the financial and insurance sector is estimated to grow by 13.2 per cent.

Government of Nepal
Office of the Prime Minister and Council of Ministers
National Statistics Office

According to the Office, the increase in deposits and loans, changes in interbank interest rates and increasing insurance premiums, among others have had a positive effect on the growth rate of the sector. Similarly, the accommodation and food service sector is expected to grow by 11.7 per cent during the review period.

The significant increase in the arrival of tourists during the first quarter of the current fiscal year has also had a positive impact on this sector.

The NSO estimated that the growth rate of the agriculture, forestry and fisheries sector, which contributes the most to the economy during this period, would be 1.4 per cent during the first quarter of the current fiscal year.

The increase in rice production also contributed to the growth rate of this sector. However, the gross value addition of the wholesale and retail trade sector will witness a fall of 1.2 per cent in the first quarter of the current fiscal year as compared to the corresponding period last year, said NSO.

Although there has been a steady increase in overall imports, the growth rate of this sector has decreased due to the decrease in tradable goods.

Similarly, the Office has estimated the growth rate of the manufacturing sector by 1.3 per cent, electricity, gas, steam and air conditioning supply by 1.6 per cent, real estate sector by 2.2 per cent, administrative and support service activities by 8.8 per cent and human health and social work activities by 1.1 per cent, education by 0.8 per cent and administrative and support service activities by 8.8 per cent during the review period.

However, seasonally adjusted quarterly gross domestic product at the basic price is estimated to decrease by 1.4 per cent in the first quarter of the current fiscal year compared to the fourth quarter of the previous fiscal year.

Looking at seasonally adjusted quarterly gross value addition, economic activities increased in 12 of the total 18 economic sectors in the first quarter of the current fiscal year (Shrawan, Bhadra and Ashoj) compared to the fourth quarter of the previous fiscal year (Baishak, Jestha and Asar), said the NSO.

The production of six sectors saw a decrease during the review period.

During the review period, the Office estimated that the total value added in the water supply; sewerage, and waste management sector would increase by 7.3 per cent.

Similarly, it is estimated that the financial and insurance sector will increase by 6.7 per cent, public administration by 5.5 per cent, and the defence, information and communication sector will improve by 3.8 per cent.

On the other hand, due to the decrease in electricity production during the review period, it is estimated that the total value addition of the electricity and gas sector will decrease by 21.9 per cent.

The Office estimates that wholesale and retail trade, and construction will decrease by 8 per cent, mining and quarrying by 5 per cent, and the total value added of the industrial sector by 3.8 per cent during the first quarter of the current fiscal year as compared to the fourth quarter of the last fiscal year.

NEA decides to reconnect power supply

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 12

The Nepal Electricity Authority (NEA) is to resume power supply to the consumers who have used electricity from dedicated feeder and trunk line in the past but have not paid premium charge for that.

The 960th meeting of the NEA Board of Directors held under chairmanship of Minister for Energy, Water Resources and Irrigation today decided to reconnect the electricity of the industries as per the decision of the cabinet meeting.

The NEA had disconnected the power supply to 24 industries that had to pay more than Rs 50 million tariff. The NEA Board of Directors had directed the NEA management to resume the power supply to such industries until the report submitted by a probe commission formed by the government and a decision taken by the government.

The Cabinet meeting held on Tuesday had formed the probe commission under coordination of former justice of the Supreme Court, Girish Chandra Lal, to recommend for the resolution of power tariff dispute surfaced between the NEA and industrialists. Secretary of the Ministry of Energy, Water Resources and irrigation, and Industry Secretary were the members of the commission.

The meeting through the Energy Ministry had directed the NEA to reconnect the power supply until the next decision of the government. The Ministry had on Thursday sent a letter to implement the directive.

During a meeting of the National Concern and Coordination Committee of the National Assembly held on Thursday, NEA Deputy Executive Director Manoj Silwal had mentioned resuming power supply after making decision from the meeting of NEA Board of Directors as per the government's directive.

Setikhola hydropower project begins power production



RSS
Parbat, Jan. 12

With the completion of the project development, the Setikhola Hydropower Project at Paiyun and Bihadi rural municipalities in Parbat district has started power generation. The project with the capacity of 3.5 megawatt has also started its test transmission, completing the entire development works in five years.

The canal headwork of the project is at Beulibas of Paiyun Rural Municipality-2 while the powerhouse is at Ghangre of Bihadi Rural Municipality-6. The water has been supplied to Ghangre through a 3,600 metres long pipe line from Beulibas. China's Asia Pacific Project carried out the electromechanical job of the project while K and K Builders from Biratnagar performed the pipeline works.

Company Secretary of the project, Dr Shiva Shankar Basyal, said that The Brothers Builders Kathmandu was assigned to build the civil construction of the project. It is said that the total cost of the project has exceeded Rs 1.1 billion.

Basyal shared that the power generated from the project will be supplied to the national grid of Nepal Electricity Authority (NEA) in two weeks adding that the power purchase agreement (PPA) has already been signed with the NEA. Siddhartha Bank Limited and Garima Development Bank have invested for the project.

Deposit mobilisation at BFIs increases by 4.6% in five months

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 12

Deposit collections of the Banks and Financial Institutions (BFIs) have increased by 4.6 per cent in the first five months of the current fiscal year 2023/24 as compared to the same period last fiscal year 2022/23.

According to the macroeconomic and financial report of the Nepal Rastra Bank, deposit collection at the BFIs has increased by Rs. 263.72 billion in the review period compared to an increase of Rs. 111.15 billion in the corresponding period of the previous year.

On y-o-y basis, deposits at BFIs expanded 15.0 per cent in mid-December 2023. The share of demand, saving and fixed deposits in total deposits stood at 6.3 per cent, 26.3 per cent and 60.7 per cent respectively in mid-December 2023.

A year ago, such shares were 7.6 per cent, 25.7 per cent and 60.3 per cent respectively. The share of institutional deposits in total deposits of BFIs stood at 36.7 per cent in mid-December 2023. Such a share was 37.2 per cent in mid-December 2022.

Similarly, private sector credit from BFIs increased by Rs. 110.06 billion (2.3 per cent) in the review period. The private sector credit from BFIs had increased by only Rs. 73.30 billion (1.6 per cent) in the corresponding period of the previous year.



On y-o-y basis, credit to the private sector from BFIs increased by 4.5 per cent in mid-December 2023. The shares of private sector credit from BFIs to non-financial corporations and household stand at 63.1 per cent and 36.9 per cent respectively in mid-December 2023.

In the review period, private sector credit from commercial banks, development banks and finance companies increased by 2.3 per cent, 2.2 per cent and 0.9 per cent respectively.

In the review period, out of the total outstanding credit of the BFIs, 11.6 per cent is against the collateral of current assets (such as agricultural and non-agricultural products) and 67.7 per cent against land and building, said the NRB. Such ratios were 12.3 per cent and 66.8 per cent respectively a year ago.

In the review period, outstanding loans of BFIs to the industrial production sector increased by 6.3 per cent, to the construction sector by 8.1 per cent, to the transportation, communication and public sector by 4.5 per cent, to the wholesale and retail sector by 1.5 per cent, to the service industry sector by 3.3 per cent and to the consumable sector by 2.2 per cent.

> The share of demand, saving and fixed deposits in total deposits stood at 6.3 per cent, 26.3 per cent and 60.7 per cent respectively in mid-December 2023.

However, agriculture sector loans fell marginally by 0.1 per cent during the review period. In the review period, term loans extended by BFIs increased by 10.3 per cent, cash credit loan by 14.5 per cent, trust receipt (import) loan by 14.5 per cent, real estate loans (including residential personal home loans) by 4.1 per cent, and margin nature loan by 6.4 per cent.

The overdraft loan decreased by 40.6 per cent (mainly due to the reclassification of the loan from the last year) and hire purchase loan decreased by 19 per cent during the review period.



PHOTO: KAVIN ADHIKARI/TRN

Workers are busy preparing Chaku in Tokha, Kathmandu. Chaku is one of the most sold verities of sweets during Maghe Sankranti festival.

Farmers attracted to beekeeping in Ilam

RSS
Ilam, Jan. 12

The number of beekeepers has surged in Rong Rural Municipality in Ilam district. With the investment from the local government to promote beekeeping, around 900 households in the rural municipality have done commercial beekeeping.

According to Rong Rural Municipality Chairman Mani Kumar Syangbo Subas, attraction of farmers towards beekeeping is impressive as the rural municipality announced its plan to open a Honey Bank, a centre for honey collection.

The beekeepers have also been given training on quality honey production and grant on beehives to encourage them towards beekeeping.

The rural municipality chairman shared that the local government invested around Rs 10 million in two years for encouraging locals for honey production. The honey producers' networks have been formed in every ward.

The rural municipality has planned to provide certain percent in grant to the beekeepers on the basis of production. "We are working on development of certain indicators for quality honey production. The farmers have to submit their application in the first month of the fiscal year to join the Honey Bank," Chairman Syangbo said.

The rural municipality would ensure the marketing of the honey produced here, he added. The rural municipality has planned to handover the management part of the proposed Honey Bank to a cooperative.

Likewise, the community forests have been directed to compulsorily implement the programme. "Annual plans of the community forest will not be approved without the programmes of the beekeeping," he added.

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Nepali Army marching to mark National Unity Day

BY KABIRAJ GHIMIRE
Dhankuta, Jan. 12

The Nepali Army organised a walk from Dharan to Dhankuta on Friday on the occasion of the National Unity Day and the birth anniversary of late King Prithvi Narayan Shah. Over 200 tourism entrepreneurs, locals and soldiers participated in the walk.

The walk began at Fusre, Dharan and ended at Sangurigadhi, Dhankuta. Sangurigadhi is a historically important site that the commander of Shah's army Abhiman Singh Basnet captured in 1774. From here, Basnet and Shah were able to conquer many northern and eastern states and bring them under a unified Nepal.

Similarly, before the construction of the Koshi Highway, Sangurigadhi was the main point through which Dhankuta residents travelled to Dharan to buy essentials like salt and cooking oil.

The march was coordinated by the army's Bhimdal Battalion. At Sangurigadhi, a programme was organised to entertain the marchers and inform them about the route they walked.

At the programme, Major General Dr. Asha Bahadur Tamang, Commanding General of the Nepali Army's Eastern Command, stressed the need to remember the contribution of our ancestors. "We should learn a lot from the work done by our ancestors to save and build the country," he said.

Jitendra Rudali Rai, chairman of the Sangurigadhi Rural Municipality, said that the local level was working to promote the area's history and tourism.



PHOTO: KABIRAJ GHIMIRE/TRN
On the occasion of the National Unity Day and the birth anniversary of late King Prithvi Narayan Shah, the Nepali Army holding a walk from Dharan to Dhankuta on Friday.

FAO, ICIMOD build partnership for climate-resilient food system

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 12

The Food and Agriculture Organisation of the United Nations (FAO) and the International Centre for Integrated Mountain Development (ICIMOD) have formalised a strategic partnership through a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) signing ceremony held in Kathmandu.

This ceremony marks a significant milestone in their collaborative efforts to strengthen partnership towards climate-resilient agri-food system transformation in Bhutan and Nepal, read a press statement issued by ICIMOD on Friday.

Dr. Pema Gyamtsho, Director-General of ICIMOD, and Ken Shimizu, FAO-Representative for Bhutan and Nepal signed the MoU in the presence of Dr. Qu Dongyu, Director-General of FAO and esteemed dignitaries, experts, and representatives from both organisations, according to the statement.

The statement read, "With a shared commitment to addressing the multifaceted challenges faced by mountain communities, FAO and ICIMOD are pooling their expertise, knowledge, innovation, technology, and networks to promote GESI responsive sustainable agricultural practices, improve natural resource management, and strengthen the overall resilience in the agri-food systems. This collaborative effort aims to tackle pressing issues such as climate change, land degradation, water scarcity, feminization, and agrobiodiversity loss."

The strategic collaboration between FAO and ICIMOD closely aligns with the vision outlined in the Mustang Declaration on Sustainable Mountain Solutions signed in September 2022, emphasizing the imperative need for cooperative endeavours among stakeholders to address challenges faced by mountain communities, it said.

FAO and ICIMOD focus on key areas including sustainable agriculture and livestock systems, food and nutrition security, climate change adaptation, and capacity building.

Their collaboration aims to strengthen food production, food and nutrition security, and economic benefits for mountain communities through inclusive practices, improved watershed management, and diverse production systems. These efforts also strive to tackle weather-related challenges and build resilience by adopting gender-responsive practices, providing climate information, and empowering vulnerable groups through skill development and early warning systems.

The ceremony comprised a series of events, featuring high-level bilateral discussions among key officials from FAO and ICIMOD, focusing on collaborative strategies, shared objectives, and joint initiatives. Remarks delivered by the respective Director-Generals underscored the significance of this partnership in advancing regional impact and promoting sustainable mountain development, the statement read.

Gyamtsho added, "This collaboration amalgamates the expertise of FAO and ICIMOD to address the intricate challenges faced by mountain communities. Our joint efforts aim to cultivate sustainable agricultural practices, fortify natural resource management, and enhance resilience in the Hindu Kush Himalaya region."

Buddhist Lamas praying in isolation for peace and non-violence

BY KEDAR TIMALSINA
Banepa, Jan. 12

Buddhist Lamas from five districts including Kavrepalanchok have been staying in isolation (Gufa) in Khanihkola Rural Municipality-5 for the past one month, praying for global peace and non-violence.

Around 100 Lamas have been staying in seclusion praying for peace since December 15 under the patronage of Konchyoksuma Nepal Tamang Lama Dhedung of Khanikhola.

Bir Bahadur Waiba, president of the organisation, said, "The Lamas have been praying for peace and non-violence. The Lamas from Kavrepalanchok, Sindhuli, Makwanpur, Chitwan and Sindhupalchok have participated in the Gufa."

Lama preacher Serap Gyalchen said that the Lamas will stay in Gufa till January 25 to learn the philosophies of Buddha.

"Training is being provided to the Lamas to make them acquainted with Buddhist knowledge, make the Lamas organised, and develop religious and cultural aptitude among Lams.

He said the number of Lama students in the Tamang community has been decreasing. Thus he hoped that the prayer organised in seclusion would help preach Buddhist doctrine to Lamas and help in the production of human resources.

It is expected that about Rs.10 million will be spent on the Gufa (chanting mantra in seclusion) that will continue for 40 days.

Khanikhola Rural Municipality Chairperson Indra Bahadur Thing expressed the belief that the gathering of Lamas from five districts would contribute to the development of religious tourism in Khanikhola.

He said that the rural municipality has forwarded its policies and programmes to develop religious tourism in the rural municipality.

Secretary of the orgnaisation, Prem Bahadur Syangtan, said that Kunchham would contribute to the promotion of Buddhism, the liberation of animals and non-living beings, non-violence and peace.

He said that 40 Lamas were attending the closed preaching classes (Gufa).

He said that extensive discussions have been held on the issue of how Lamas' could contribute to non-violence and world peace, and how they can contribute to the promotion and spread of Buddhist philosophy.



PHOTO: KEDAR TIMALSINA/TRN
As seen in the picture, the Buddhist Lamas from five districts including Kavrepalanchok have been staying in isolation (Gufa) in Khanikhola Rural Municipality-5 for the past one month, praying for global peace and non-violence.

Jhapa celebrating 'Bhakka Day' to promote traditional cuisine

BY BISHNU PRASAD POKHAREL
Damak, Jan. 12

People of the Koch Rajbanshi community living in Eastern Nepal have been celebrating the 29th day of Poush, a month in the Nepali calendar, as 'Bhakka Day' for the past seven years. The day falls on January 14 this year.

Three local levels of Jhapa district have announced a public holiday on the day. Bhadrapur Municipality, Kachankawal Rural Municipality and Haldibari Rural Municipaliy have given a holiday on Poush 29 as the local levels have a majority of the people from indigenous communities.

Bhakka is made by steaming rice flour in a small cake-like structure. It is often eaten during breakfast throughout the Tarai districts of the east. For many, Bhakka is a good breakfast with tea, especially during the winter.

Many women from different communities can be seen placing small Bhakka stalls at the main junctions and along the highways early morning. Those stalls remain crowded until the afternoon.

While Bhakka Day was celebrated only by the community people, stakeholders have now started celebrating it with grandeur.

"Celebrating the day extravagantly will promote the food across many faraway places. We have started receiving more support and participation from other communities and local governments for the day," said Abhay Rajbanshi, chairman of Rajbanshi Community Development Committee.

According to Abhay, this year, the day is being celebrated by organising a programme at the Birtamod-based Domlal Rajbanshi Ground.

More than 150 women from indigenous communities will be selling Bhakkas in the programme. The organisers have expected at least 35,000 celebrants at the event.



PHOTO: BISHNU PRASAD POKHAREL/TRN
People of the Koch Rajbanshi community living in Eastern Nepal have been celebrating the 29th day of Poush, a month in the Nepali calendar, as 'Bhakka Day'.

Mahabir Pun on book promotion tour with mission to restart factory

BY AMAR RAJ NAHARKI
Tanahun, Jan. 12

It is the month of January and so cold that people can barely go out after the sun sets. But on Thursday, renowned personality Mahabir Pun was out on the streets of Damauli till 9 pm selling his books.

He was being helped by volunteers from the Leo Club of Tanahun but Pun was the one making the most effort, signing copies of his autobiography titled after him and taking pictures with his admirers.

From the crowd gathered around him, it is evident that the people of Damauli love Pun.

And Pun greatly appreciates this love, but he has little time to revel in it for he is currently touring the country trying to sell as many of his books as he can.

He will use the funds collected to bring the Krishi Aujar Karkhana (Agriculture Implements Factory), which has been closed for nearly 30 years, back into operation. The government gave Pun's National Innovation Centre (NIC) the responsibility to run and manage the factory in 2022.

Pun began his book-selling tour from Monday. First, he went to Dhading from Kathmandu. He then travelled to Gorkha on Tuesday and Lamjung on Wednesday. He came to Tanahun on Thursday. He reached Pokhara on Friday.

Pun's autobiography contains stories of his successes and struggles and presents inspirational facets of his life. He informed that he had sold 24,500 copies of the book till Thursday. He also told The Rising Nepal that his NIC had repaired most of the equipment at the Krishi Karkhana and now required Rs. 150 million to Rs. 200 million to get it up and running. To raise this amount, Pun plans to sell 300,000 books (each book costs Rs. 750).

Indra Bahadur Thapa, who presently lives in Damauli, said he came to buy Pun's book because he agreed with his campaign and wanted to support it. That is why, despite needing only one, Thapa bought four copies of the book.

Sagar Udas, former chairman of the Gandaki Literary Academy, said he came to meet and encourage Pun. "He is a national treasure," he said.

MAYOR OF PHIDIM HANDS OVER HOUSE TO POOR COUPLE

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Phidim, Jan. 12

Phidim Municipality Mayor Mitra Prasad Kafle has handed over a house constructed with his money to a couple living in a hut near a forest in Budhuk, Ward No. 12 of the municipality.

As per his commitment to uplifting the underprivileged community, Mayor Kafle constructed the two-storey house at a cost of Rs. 165,000 for Karna Bahadur Thamsuhang and Manmaya Thamsuhang.

Earlier, Mayor Kafle had committed to establishing a separate fund using the allowances provided by the state to the mayor and using it to support the livelihood, education, health and income generation of underprivileged communities.

He had also supported various underprivileged communities in the municipal area in the past.

The Thamsuhang couple was living a miserable life earning a living by grinding stones.

Citizens queuing up to fill biometrics in Mahottari

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Bardibas, Jan. 12

There has been a surge in the number of people coming to fill out the biometrics forms for national identity cards at the local levels in Mahottari district.

The locals had to stand in a long queue when the authorities were unable to manage the crowd properly. In some places, people had to return home without filling up their details even after waiting for hours for their turn.

According to Assistant Chief District Officer Upendra Neupane, currently, all the 15 local levels of Mahottari, the Area Administrations and two places of the District Administration Office are collecting the details for the national ID.

At the local levels, most of the elderly people are visiting the ward offices while youth are visiting the administration and area administration offices to fill out the biometric forms.

It is said that details of more than a thousand people are collected daily in all 15 local levels of Mahottari.

On the other hand, the Area Administration Office in Bardibas and Gaushala and the District Administration Office in Mahottari informed that up to 300 people come daily for biometrics.

As the number of people seeking National ID cards is increasing, Samsi Rural Municipality has designated alternate days for each ward number to come to the office to fill up the biometric records.

According to Chief Administrative Officer Ganesh Chandra Mishra of the Municipality, six wards of the Rural Municipality have been assigned six different days to fill up the biometric forms.

The crowd in the municipal office has also decreased after an alternate system was implemented," said Mishra.

Sunil Sharma, the head of the Area Administration Office, Bardibas, said that the office has implemented a token system to manage the crowd as up to 100 people a day started coming for biometrics. According to him, tokens for up to January 25 have been distributed to the locals.

The Area Administration Office, Gaushala, informed that about 19,845 citizens have filled up their biometric forms from the Gaushala office alone.

Kiran Nidhi Tiwari, Chief Administrative Officer of Bardibas Municipality, said that the number of people coming to fill out biometric forms has increased rapidly after biometric details were made mandatory to update the details of the social security allowance.

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

Funny is an attitude.

-- Flip Wilson

Widening Boundaries Of Politics

Dev Raj Dahal



The edifice of modern politics is not solely confined to the state as it does not live up to its own rules. Not even political parties which too intrude their statutes as per the changing conditions of electorates. The habitat of politics has expanded beyond selfish biological nature and cunning art of rhetoric. Now, it is rationalised on the basis of the sublime public and national interests it serves. Universal consciousness, new economy, technology and ecology have enlarged the sphere of politics to a larger dimension and scale. Now, civil servants, civil society, business, citizen groups, professional and interest based links and even global forces join in and influence national political activities, put forward their demands, claim rights and lobby in the media of communication, institutions and government for the satisfaction of their interests. Politics obviously relates to power, an enabling condition to take binding decisions. But it is not only the state, political system, government and political parties serving as sites of power pyramid. Enlightenment, institutions, civil society, market forces, citizen groups, social movements, international community, etc. also compose a source of power, authority and legitimacy. They have become a visible spell of power to ensure public good, the very emblem of politics.

Accountability

Political power is based on public opinion and the general consent of people expressed through fair elections and constitutional tradition. It requires the periodic renewal of its legitimacy. It is delicate and fragile also. If people withdraw their consent in a rumble of rage, it instantly collapses like a house of cards. The use of political power by leadership requires prudence, that is, power is used in an authoritative style and justly to flourish the domain of public life. Its unjust use is often questioned by people, hotly debated in the media and civil society, contested in the courts and catches the global gaze. Political power demands accountability to public and national interests. Its unaccountable use wears the marks of calamity. If one look into the timeless insight of political power in Michel Foucault terms it is about "resistance" of people and their "anti-authority struggle" against exploitation, control and unjust domination. It opens two sides of political power: positional and oppositional. The resistance to power soars uphill when losers in the political game outnumber the winners causing its atrophy and paralysis.

Democracy has made politics a realm of public life. It is here Nepalis exercise their constitutional and human rights to argue, contest, set agenda and resolve issues and conflicts. The vigorous debate in the public sphere, about the ends and means of politics and general idea of progress help unequal people share public policy space and transform themselves into equal citizens by changing the condition of living. Politics cannot be privatised and denationalised the way it is done in authoritarian regimes. Self-rule is its democratic standards. As Nepalis find political parties' decision making highly top-down it has opened dissent both within the parties and outside. The howls against vices of corruption, erosion of eco-balance of hills and Himalayas, gender-based violence, human trafficking, smuggling of gold and personalising public lands are hitting public debate. Cultural alignment has also pervaded the domain of politics demonstrating their inseparability. Those advocating alternative politics of justice oppose its governmentalisation or partisanisation which does not take into account the boundaries of either the state, policy or people. The contestability of power needs to be settled so that it can serve the purpose of statecraft and manage multi-scale politics in its ancient wisdom of the middle path by eradicating the injustices of many ideologies.

Post-Class Politics: The class based ideological politics sought to redistribute power and property in society to peasants and laborers. The post-class politics of Nepal encourages informalisation and migration of workers, supports premature de-industrialisation, inclusion of females in the labour market, social representation and recognition of several identities of people. The necessity of electoral alignment, power sharing of all with all has blunted the sharpness of ideological lens. The issue oriented Nepali parties such as Rastriya Swotantra Party (RSP) and Rastriya Prajatantra Party are raising concern about the huge migration of youth, students and businesspersons abroad and conversion of Nepalis into Bhutanese refugees. This migration is not just a matter of push and pull factors or homophobia but also a matter of new politics in response to global demand and supply. The old politics has tried the coherence of the state, economy and people into national space while the new politics found divergence in all these realms and, therefore, leaders of new parties are visiting those places where Nepalis are clustered for electoral appeal and seek goodness of rule. Post-class politics tries to cope with the rise of multi-classes beyond the old identities of the covetous capital and the wage labor. Gender, climate change, migration, minorities etc. have become cross-cutting themes. Post-class politics traverses the ideological boundaries and indulges in multiple citizenships, if not the one humanity.

Network Politics: The information revolution has shifted the territorialised solidarity politics into network based. Social media has made each Nepali conscious of his or her condition, know job opportunities through the internet and move to tap them across the globe. Interacting nature of networks has provided them judgmental ability and exercise politics of choice outside the nation. Globalisation of political economy has homogenised Nepali mainstream parties such as NC, CPN-UML and Maoist Center, expunged the right-center-left political spectrum and made them catch-all. As a result, they have lost class-based appeal although the struggle of loan-shark victims gives a veneer of class conflict. It is, however, also connected with other money lending institutions. Rapid urbanisation, migration, increased divorce rate, etc. are turning social life increasingly atomised, autonomous, flexible and contractual, lacking the emotional solidarity of class action. People drift to social media for instant information unmediated by business or partisan prejudice although its self-accountability remains hazy. The neoliberal ethos of cut in agricultural subsidy and privatisation of most of public industries, labour market flexibility and no-work no pay adopted by Nepali governments have debased the economic base of Nepali state. It has forced political parties and economic elites to cultivate the symbolic economy, thus fraying the traditional faith in patrimonial leadership. Now Nepalis demand leadership with actual transformational vision.

> The contestability of power needs to be settled so that it can serve the purpose of statecraft and manage multi-scale politics in its ancient wisdom of the middle path by eradicating the injustices of many ideologies.

Identity politics: The Nepali constitution has defined varied forms of citizenship and their national inclusive commissions for some cluster of people to foster identity politics. As a result, socialisation along these lines has devalued the national identity of citizenship. They negotiate with the party leaders on the basis of social identity. This has strained value-based politics. Mass tribalisation is claiming to represent social identity above partisan identity. These identity groups build networks with like-minded people across the parties, constitution and national frontiers seeking special privileges for them, thus deflating party discipline and affinity.

The increasing clientalisation of Nepalis to global politics has a geopolitical dimension. They are spread in over 100 nations but claim Nepali identity. Many professional groups get support from global powers and act as their soft power proxies, thus fading constitutional discipline. As a result, Nepali politics has been disembodied from native society. Decision making too became unreflective of the human condition of Nepalis, nurturing national cultural values and protection of habitat. The democratic upswing is cut by a lack of reflection on the classical democratic doctrine of subsidiarity and popular sovereignty.

Egalitarian aspirations

Emancipatory politics: Unlike the past, none of Nepali political parties uphold the ideal of emanciapotry politics of self-awakening now as they are saturated with materialism and confined with huge rights with few duties. It supports only the organised and conscious parts of society, not the mostly informal society, economy and polity. The liberation of the oppressed through their supply to the global labor market has expanded the arena of politics to global scale. Political parties, civil society, NGOs and business compete with the state for global resources and legitimacy. If Nepali parties, the wherewithal of democracy, are only partly democratic in their leadership, culture, structure and policies, the polity fails to operate in a democratic and accountable way. The cultic nature of power in Nepal does not rear democratic cognition, attitudes, values and orientations vital to foster civic culture which can pull the nation back to stability.

Deterritorialized politics: The social movements of Nepal, infused by egalitarian aspirations, mark a departure from party-parliament-government-polity nexus as their adherents find Nepali politics represented by business interests where the general concern to the public is sullen. The disfigurement of electoral politics by the rise of its costs, over use of unregulated money in publicity, electoral malpractices and vote-buying and selling are dire signs. It has infected the fairness of electoral politics and shifted the motive of politics from public service to career opportunity, thus turning it into a more self-referential game, not the wellbeing of all. In Nepal, the language of politics is marked more by mutual blame of each other's leaders than mutual responsibility thus trespassing the boundaries of political decency and moral code thus unbounding politics to all over the place. Its accountability to demos is vital for functional democracy.

(Former Reader at the Department of Political Science, TU, Dahal writes on political and social issues.)

Power Of Humour

AASHISH MISHRA

In writing and general discussion, we often think of levity and gravity as mutually exclusive, that serious issues should not be presented humorously, and humour must not discuss weighty elements. Indeed, mixing the two seems counterintuitive. Making topics that demand public awareness and attention, like conflict, environmental problems and social evils, funny might appear disrespectful, while incorporating elements of death and tragedy into jokes may defeat the primary purpose of making people forget their worries and laugh.

But even though it appears to defy logic, we can use humour when writing or speaking on consequential topics because it can be a powerful tool for engagement and a catalyst for understanding and retention.

First and foremost, humour helps capture the audience's attention – a must when presenting big concepts and communicating important ideas. A monotonous bombardment of unexciting information will put people off, especially if it is information they are not comfortable acknowledging. Humour, with its ability to surprise and entertain, can break this monotony.

By injecting a bit of comedy into the delivery of a serious message, communicators can both bring people into their writings or speeches and retain their attention. There is a reason satirical cartoons and memes get more fanfare on social media than op-eds or research papers. The former is also more memorable. You may remember a funny photo or GIF you saw some weeks ago more clearly than a solemn news story you read only a few days ago. The aim is to get people thinking while laughing and use delight to cut deep.

Secondly, humour breaks down barriers. As mentioned above, grim information, especially if it is on a topic people are not too open about, will make people apathetic at best and confrontational at worst. Getting the delivery wrong can breed resentment and instigate conflict. Humour, though, makes these topics feel less pointed and makes the audience more receptive to the message being conveyed.

Comedy sands off the sharp edges. For example, calling someone old can be offensive but referring to them as a vintage model can bring a smile to their face. And that is what scribes and speakers should strive for. Making people laugh through words fosters a connection that, in turn, makes it easier to reach out to the audience and make them see the world through a different point of view.

In other words, what humour does is build empathy. Serious presentation of serious issues makes people feel overwhelmed and powerless. They feel the problem is much bigger than they are and that their actions will not bring any change. This is what we see when it comes to climate change and green practices. People say that they alone buying an electric car or producing less waste will not solve the climate crisis, so they do not do anything.

When serious issues are tinted with levity though, it brings the large issue down to a human scale and makes the subject matter more relatable. Saying "Global warming means you will never be able to wear the pricey fur coat you bought last month" makes the issue more personal than simply announcing "The planet is heating up."

Thirdly, humour creates positive associations. When people smile about a certain topic, they will subconsciously associate it with happiness. This will make them more receptive to, or at least less uncomfortable with, acknowledging the issue. A funny advertisement on handwashing is likelier to get people to wash their hands than a straightforward public service announcement. That is why the old tele-serials by Madan Krishna Shrestha and Hari Bansha Acharya were so effective at raising public awareness. They infused humour into serious messages.

Funny things also tend to get shared a lot. This enhances their reach and impact. Ultimately, humour disarms the audience and allows for open and frank discussions. It creates a friendlier atmosphere and encourages audience members to speak up. There is less hostility and blame-throwing and even the most poignant criticisms can be passed off as witty jokes. So, everyone can be at ease expressing themselves and put their two cents in. The room becomes more collaborative.

But there is a limit. There are some topics that should never be made light of. There are some subjects that the audience should be made uncomfortable with. The world can be a cruel and unfair place and sometimes, people need to be hit in the face with that cruelty and unfairness. Other times, though, if we can laugh about something, we should. After all, they say laughter is the best medicine.

Understanding Phenomenon Of Nepali Exodus

Sugam Gautam



Every day, a massive crowd is spotted at Tribhuvan International Airport. The crowd comprises both those coming to Nepal and, in great numbers, those leaving the country in pursuit of lucrative jobs and better education. While the exodus of people is sometimes seen as the boon of globalisation, it nevertheless sparks the government's inability to create more job opportunities. At a time when the economy is struggling and many businesses are on the brink of collapsing, foreign employment, at least, is helping the dejected Nepali eke out a living. It is beginning to dawn on the citizens that the lofty promises of politicians aren't going to help them make ends meet. As a result, more and more people have started relying on the alternative opportunity, and also the ideal one at the moment — that is to board the plane and land wherever they can make more bucks than they do in Nepal.

Flawed system

The desperation of 12th-passed students to leave the country says a lot about the uncertainty looming in the Nepali air. They dread just imagining four-long years of a Bachelor's degree at a Nepali university, only to remain jobless after graduation. What could be more ironic than the situation where citizens are fist-pumping upon getting a green signal to leave their motherland? How can the leaders in power sleep soundly after thrusting the country into this sorry state? Alone in 2023, more than one lakh students acquired NOC, a document issued by the government of Nepal that permits a person to study or work abroad. This hints at the shortcomings that Nepali universities have no interest in addressing.

Recently, Tribhuvan University, the largest and oldest university in the country, rejoiced in the famous success of graduating the record number of students in its 49th convocation. While it was a milestone for the university, it might not hold the same for the graduated students. What lies ahead for them is a series of frustrations if they are to settle in the country itself. To apply for foreign jobs, their credentials don't match the high standards set by foreign employers. A number of jobs offered by the government aren't, ironically, enough for the dwindling number of graduate students.

The spearheads of the university must know that this quantitative success will do little to camouflage the flawed system persisting over the years. Students at Tribhuvan University always complain of delayed results that affect their career while also subjecting them to anxiety, depression, and more severe disorders. Other universities such as Kathmandu University and Pokhara University are comparatively in good command with fewer resources to take care of. As the institution responsible for shaping the future of the largest number of students in Nepal, TU must not only address existing issues but also formulate and implement policies that encourage students to reconsider the allure of studying abroad.

Not every Nepali student can afford to continue their studies without doing part-time jobs on the side. Middle-class families expect their children to start earning while also continuing their studies. In the jobless market of Nepal, how many students will get a part-time job? And even if they do, will it cover their own expenses? The money they earn never serves the familial needs, for it gets consumed covering their own expenditure. That is when a wave of frustration sweeps through the young population. There's no system yet for the hourly payment of workers. The very reason why Nepali students see no future in Nepal is the low wage rate accompanied by delayed payment. The challenges have escalated to a point where the students' families have sold their properties to send the children overseas. The minimum wage rate in Australia stands at 21.38 Australian dollars per hour, a far cry from what people in Nepal earn. That is enough money to make them independent. Strong economic security, lucrative job opportunities, and effective labour laws lure the Nepali students to countries like Australia, the US, Canada, and the UK, among others.

> Strong economic security, lucrative job opportunities, and effective labour laws lure the Nepali students to countries like Australia, the US, Canada, and the UK, among others.

Lacklustre response

With an increasing mass departure every year and the government's lacklustre response to regulate the crisis, the path ahead is doom and gloom. The growing attraction towards foreign countries drains the Nepali colleges. Let's not be pessimistic and search the room for optimism. Remittance has always been one of the biggest sources to contribute to the economy. But what per cent of money do the students contribute that comes to Nepal in the form of remittance? Students going for overseas education to countries like the US, Australia, Canada, and the UK spend a lot on their education and travel. Upon graduation, they are financially sound, secured and ready to apply for the Green card, granting them citizenship in their host country.

The reluctance to return to politically unstable and economically crippled nation, whose situation is worsening, is understandable. While those with a strong sense of nationalism might return, the government must convincingly channel these competent resources into strategic positions. The chances of majority of Nepali returning to Nepal is severely low given the provisions for green card holders in well-developed countries. With their families settled abroad, their contributions to Nepal dwindle, impacting every aspect of the country. Eventually the flow of money diminishes, leading to a halt in their investments and tax contributions, all of which go into the coffers of foreign governments. This phenomenon tells that the Nepali government is handing over the skilled resources to the benefit of foreign countries. If we assess all these factors, we can easily answer who's on the losing side.

(Gautam is a Pokhara-based freelance writer)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

January 13, 1974

No Restriction On Nepalese Newspapers

New Delhi, Jan.12: Indian government does not propose to put any restrictions on the sale of "The Rising Nepal", an English daily, and "Gorkhapatra", a Nepalese language daily, and other Nepalese newspapers in India. (UNI, RSS).

NOTICE TO CONTRIBUTORS

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READER'S MAIL

Remittance For Prosperity



Regarding the news story, "*Remittance growth helping external sector of economy,*" published on Jan. 12 in this daily, we should use the inflow of dollars to pull the cooperatives out of the cesspool. How? Allow them, the selected, clean ones, to transfer remittances.

As a socialist nation, we should not just allow remittances to pile up in the banks alone and must spread the fruits of the tears and sweat of the ordinary people to uplift them. The money would stir the cash flow of the cooperatives and help them to keep their image and business safe.

In a related news story published on Jan 11, our honourable finance minister is wooing investors in Gujarat to benefit from bottomless opportunities in hydro, tourism, agriculture and IT.

We could expect the investors to splurge their money here, which will help us scramble out of the LDC club. There are enough signs on the horizon to infer that the country is galloping on the path to prosperity.

Manohar Shrestha
Kathmandu

TAILPIECE

Old Josh was sat in his garden, sunbathing in the deck chair when he noticed his grand-son kneeling on the lawn with a worm. When he asked his grandson what he was doing, he found that he was trying to push the worm down the hole from which it came.

"If you can get that worm back in that hole I'll give you ten dollars," said Josh.

His grandson sat and thought for a moment, then rushed into the house. A few minutes later he returned with his mother's hair spray. He picked up the worm by one end and, as he let it hang down, he sprayed it all over with the hair spray. The spray set and the worm became stiff and hard. It was now easy to push the worm back in the hole. Josh was amazed. He gave the boy ten dollars, picked up the hair spray and went indoors.

About an hour later Josh came back into the garden and gave his grand-son another ten dollars.

"But grandpa," said the boy, "you've already given me the ten dollars you promised."

"That's from your grandma," said Josh.

US, UK strike Houthi targets in Yemen

AP
Sanna, Jan. 12



PHOTO: AP

In this image provided by the UK Ministry of Defence taken on Thursday Jan. 11, 2024 shows an RAF Typhoon aircraft taking off from RAF Akrotiri in Cyprus, for a mission to strike targets in Yemen.

US and British forces struck rebel-held Yemen early on Friday after weeks of disruptive attacks on Red Sea shipping by Iran-backed Houthi rebels who say they act in solidarity with Gaza.

The pre-dawn air strikes add to escalating fears of wider conflict in the region, where violence involving Tehran-aligned groups in Yemen as well as Lebanon, Iraq and Syria has surged since the Israel-Hamas war began in early October.

Iran "strongly condemned" the strikes, which the United States, Britain and eight other allies said aimed to "de-escalate tensions". Nasser Kanani, spokesman for Iran's foreign ministry, said that the Western strikes "will have no result other than fuelling insecurity and instability in the region", while "diverting the world's attention" from Gaza.

China said it was "concerned about the escalation of tensions in the Red Sea", and news of the strikes sent oil prices up more than 2 percent.

The Houthis have carried out a growing number of attacks on what they deem to be Israeli-linked shipping in the Red Sea, a key international trade route, since October 7, when the Hamas-led attack on Israel sparked the war which is still raging in the besieged Gaza Strip.

The rebels have controlled a major part of Yemen since a civil war erupted there in 2014 and are part of a regional Iran-backed "axis of resistance" against Israel and its allies.

Friday's strikes targeted an airbase, airports and a military camp, the Houthis' Al-Masirah TV station said, with AFP correspondents and witnesses reporting they could hear heavy strikes in Hodeida and Sanaa. "Our country was subjected to a massive aggressive attack by American and British ships, submarines and warplanes," said Hussein al-Ezzi, the rebels' deputy foreign minister. "America and Britain will have to prepare to pay a heavy price and bear all the dire consequences of this blatant aggression," he added, according to official Houthi media.

US President Joe Biden called the strikes a "defensive action" after the Red Sea attacks and said he "will not hesitate" to order further military action if needed.

With fighter jets and Tomahawk missiles, 60 targets at 16 Houthi locations were hit by more than 100 precision-guided munitions, US Central Command said in a statement.

Unverified images on social media, some of them purportedly of Al-Dailami airbase north of the rebel-held capital Sanaa, showed explosions lighting up the sky as loud bangs and the roar of planes sounded. Houthi military spokesman Yahya Saree said at least five people had been killed.

In a statement, Biden called the strikes a success and said he ordered them "against a number of targets in Yemen used by Houthi rebels to endanger freedom of navigation in one of the world's most vital waterways". Biden called the strikes a "direct response" to the "unprecedented" attacks by the Houthis which included "the use of anti-ship ballistic missiles for the first time in history".

Blaming the Houthis for ignoring "repeated warnings", British Prime Minister Rishi Sunak said in a statement the strikes were "necessary and proportionate".

Britain's defence ministry released footage of Royal Air Force jets returning to their Cyprus base after the mission, and US Centcom video showed warplanes apparently taking off from a sea-based carrier. US Defence Secretary Lloyd Austin said the strikes "targeted sites associated with the Houthis' unmanned aerial vehicle, ballistic and cruise missile, and coastal radar and air surveillance capabilities".

Japan launches satellite to watch actions of NKorea

AP
Tokyo, Jan. 12



PHOTO: AP

An H2A rocket is lifted from the launch pad at Tanegashima Space Center in Kagoshima, southern Japan Friday, Jan. 12, 2024.

Japan successfully launched a rocket carrying a government intelligence-gathering satellite Friday on a mission to watch movements at military sites in North Korea and to improve responses to natural disasters.

The H2A rocket, launched by Mitsubishi Heavy Industries Ltd., lifted off from the Tanegashima Space Center in southwestern Japan, carrying the optical satellite as part of Tokyo's reconnaissance effort to rapidly build up its military capability.

The government's Cabinet Satellite Intelligence Centre and MHI declared the launch a success, saying that the Optical-8 satellite was successfully separated from the rocket and entered its planned orbit.

The optical satellite can capture detailed images, though its capability is limited in severe weather. Japan began the intelligence-gathering satellite program after a North Korean missile flew over Japan in 1998. Japan aims to set up a network of 10 satellites, including those carrying radars that can operate at night or in severe weather, to spot and provide early warning for possible missile launches.

Applauding the successful launch, Hiroki Yasuda, a senior official at the Cabinet Satellite Intelligence Centre, told reporters that the Optical-8 is crucial to Japan's information-gathering capability. It will take several months for the satellite to start supplying information, Yasuda said.

Yasuda said the existing network of intelligence satellites, including those used beyond operational life, captured images of quake-hit western Japan Japan for disaster response purposes. The New Year's Day temblors killed 215 people and caused extensive damages to buildings, roads and lifeline.

Prime Minister Fumio Kishida's government, under its national security strategy adopted in 2022, is pushing to deploy long-range U.S.-made Tomahawk and other cruise missiles as early as next year to build up more strike capability, breaking from the country's exclusively self-defense-only postwar principle, citing rapid weapons advancement in China and North Korea.

TRUMP BERATES JUDGE DURING CIVIL FRAUD TRIAL

AFP
New York, Jan. 12

Donald Trump ignored warnings from the judge in his New York civil fraud trial Thursday and turned closing arguments into an election campaign attack, claiming that prosecutors are out to stop his political comeback.

Prosecutors are demanding $370 million from Trump over fraud allegations -- and to bar him from conducting business in the state where he made his name as a celebrity real estate tycoon.

Trump had sought to deliver full closing arguments himself, but permission was denied when he failed to sign off on restrictions aimed at stopping him from using the courtroom as an electioneering platform.

Judge Arthur Engoron then allowed Trump to make brief additional comments after his lawyer had spoken -- again insisting that the Republican presidential candidate and former president respect courtroom rules.

Trump almost immediately launched into a bitter attack on the New York state attorney general, saying, "They want to make sure I never win again. The (attorney general) hates Trump... and if I can't talk about that it's a disservice."

Engoron attempted to interrupt Trump with a warning to wrap up his statement and Trump responded: "You have your own agenda, you can't listen for more than one minute."

Engoron told Trump's lawyer to "control your client."

UK PM Sunak visits Kyiv to announce support package for Ukraine

AP
Kyiv, Ukraine, Jan. 12



PHOTO: AP

Britain's Prime Minister Rishi Sunak, top right, sits next to Vice Chief of the Defence Staff Major General Gwyn Jenkins, left, near Kyiv, Ukraine, Friday Jan. 12, 2024.

U.K. Prime Minister Rishi Sunak travelled to Kyiv on Friday to unveil a new support package for Ukraine, including an increase in military funding for its war with Russia that after 22 months shows no sign of ending.

The 2.5 billion pounds ($3.2 billion) in military funding for Ukraine over the next financial year will cover long-range missiles, thousands of drones, air defense, artillery ammunition and maritime security, according to a statement from Sunak's office.

Those are some of the items that Kyiv officials have been urging Ukraine's Western allies to send more of, as the grinding war of attrition brings little change along the front line and both sides turn to long-range strikes.

Ukraine and Russia are seeking to replenish their arsenals this year, military analysts say, in anticipation of possible major ground offensives in 2025.

"I am here today with one message: the U.K. will also not falter," Sunak said. "We will stand with Ukraine, in their darkest hours and in the better times to come."

Sunak first visited Ukraine in November 2022, soon after he became prime minister. Britain has been one of Ukraine's most vocal backers.

Britain is the second-biggest donor of military aid to Ukraine after the U.S., giving a total of 4.6 billion pounds ($3.3 billion) in 2022 and 2023.

Ukraine's leader, Volodymyr Zelenskyy, is pushing Kyiv's Western allies to provide Ukraine with more support on top of the billions of dollars in military aid the country has already received.

This week he visited three small Baltic countries — Lithuania, Estonia and Latvia — in search of new pledges. The eastern European countries, which are also amongst Kyiv's staunchest supporters, promised more missiles, drones, howitzers and artillery shells.

Zelenskyy has warned that Ukraine particularly needs air defense systems to fend off Russian aerial barrages. Recent massive Russian barrages — more than 500 drones and missiles were fired between Dec. 29 and Jan. 2, according to officials in Kyiv — are using up Ukraine's air defense resources and leaving it vulnerable.

Sunak said that the U.K. recognizes that Ukrainian security "is our security," as Kyiv's forces stand up to Russian President Vladimir Putin's full-scale invasion.

PRISM

Australian woman wins 'World's Ugliest Lawn' competition

Sanford: An Australian woman's bandicoot-ravaged yard was dubbed the winner of the first-ever World's Ugliest Lawn competition.

Kathleen Murray of Sanford, Tasmania, was named the winner of the contest, which was organised by the town of Gotland, Sweden.

Gotland started the contest two years ago to encourage locals to conserve water amid a near-disastrous drought in the town, and this year the contest went global, with lawns in the United States, Canada, Britain, Germany, France and Croatia competing for unaesthetic honors. Murray's lawn features sparse patches of yellow grass, shrivelled plants and dry divots caused by the local bandicoots.

Pet goat rescued from roof of home

Arizona: An Arizona fire department said it was a "rooftop rodeo" when firefighters were called to rescue a pet goat that found its way onto the roof of a home and became stranded.

The Glendale Fire Department said in a Facebook post that firefighters were called to "lend a helping

Photos from the "rooftop rodeo" show firefighters climbing up on the roof to bring the goat back down to earth.

The goat was reunited with its owner.

(AP)

TODAY IN HISTORY

27 BC – Octavian transfers the state to the free disposal of the Roman Senate and the people. He receives Spain, Gaul, and Syria as his province for ten years.
1815 – War of 1812: British troops capture Fort Peter in St. Marys, Georgia, the only battle of the war to take place in the state.
1847 – The Treaty of Cahuenga ends the Mexican–American War in California.
1849 – Establishment of the Colony of Vancouver Island.
1849 – Second Anglo-Sikh War: Battle of Chillianwala: British forces retreat from the Sikhs.
1888 – The National Geographic Society is founded in Washington, D.C.
1893 – The Independent Labour Party of the United Kingdom holds its first meeting.
1893 – U.S. Marines land in Honolulu, Hawaii from the USS Boston to prevent the queen from abrogating the Bayonet Constitution.
1895 – First Italo-Ethiopian War: The war's opening battle, the Battle of Coatit, occurs; it is an Italian victory.
1898 – Émile Zola's J'accuse…! exposes the Dreyfus affair.

'Lost valley of cities' uncovered in Ecuador

AP
Andes, Ecuador, Jan. 12

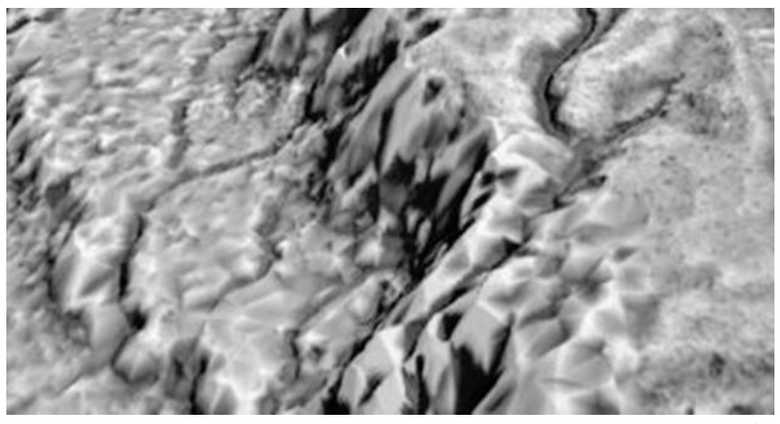


PHOTO: AP

This LIDAR image shows complexes of rectangular platforms arranged around low squares and distributed along wide dug streets at the Kunguints site, Upano Valley, in Ecuador.

Archeologists have uncovered a cluster of lost cities in the Amazon rainforest that was home to at least 10,000 farmers around 2,000 years ago.

A series of earthen mounds and buried roads in Ecuador was first noticed more than two decades ago by archaeologist Stéphen Rostain.

But at the time, "I wasn't sure how it all fit together," said Rostain, one of the researchers who reported on the finding Thursday in the journal Science.

Recent mapping by laser-sensor technology revealed those sites to be part of a dense network of settlements and connecting roadways, tucked into the forested foothills of the Andes that lasted about 1,000 years.

"It was a lost valley of cities," said Rostain, who directs investigations at France's National Centre for Scientific Research. "It's incredible."

The settlements were occupied by the Upano people between around 500 B.C. and 300 to 600 A.D. – a period roughly contemporaneous with the Roman Empire in Europe, the researchers found.

Residential and ceremonial buildings erected on more than 6,000 earthen mounds were surrounded by agricultural fields with drainage canals. The largest roads were 33 feet (10 metres) wide and stretched for 6 to 12 miles (10 to 20 kilometres).

While it's difficult to estimate populations, the site was home to at least 10,000 inhabitants – and perhaps as many as 15,000 or 30,000 at its peak, said archaeologist Antoine Dorison, a study co-author at the same French institute. That's comparable to the estimated population of Roman-era London, then Britain's largest city.

"This shows a very dense occupation and an extremely complicated society," said University of Florida archeologist Michael Heckenberger, who was not involved in the study. "For the region, it's really in a class of its own in terms of how early it is."

José Iriarte, a University of Exeter archaeologist, said it would have required an elaborate system of organized labour to build the roads and thousands of earthen mounds.

"The Incas and Mayans built with stone, but people in Amazonia didn't usually have stone available to build – they built with mud. It's still an immense amount of labour," said Iriarte, who had no role in the research.

The Amazon is often thought of as a "pristine wilderness with only small groups of people.

But recent discoveries have shown us how much more complex the past really is," he said.

Scientists have recently also found evidence of intricate rainforest societies that predated European contact elsewhere in the Amazon, including in Bolivia and in Brazil.

"There's always been an incredible diversity of people and settlements in the Amazon, not only one way to live," said Rostain. "We're just learning more about them."

FAO CHIEF CALLS ON PRESIDENT

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 12

Director-General of the United Nations Food and Agriculture Organisation (FAO) Dr. Qu Dongyu paid a courtesy call on President Ramchandra Paudel at the latter's office on Friday.

As per a statement released by the President's Office, the President appreciated the FAO for the support it has provided to Nepal to ensure food and nutrition security, manage natural resources, develop agriculture and build capacity.

'MYANMAR MILITARY, ETHNIC GUERRILLA GROUPS HAVE AGREED TO A CEASE-FIRE'

AP
Beijing, Jan. 12

Myanmar's military has reached a cease-fire agreement with an alliance of ethnic minority guerrilla groups it has been battling in the north, the Chinese Foreign Ministry said Friday.

The agreement was brokered at talks mediated by China on Wednesday and Thursday in Kunming, a Chinese provincial capital about 400 kilometers (250 miles) from the border with Myanmar, Foreign Ministry spokesperson Mao Ning said.

"China hopes the relevant parties in Myanmar can conscientiously implement the agreement, exercise maximum restraint toward each other and solve the issues through dialogue and consultations," she said at a daily briefing in Beijing.

Myanmar has been wracked by violence that began after the army ousted the elected government of Aung San Suu Kyi in February 2021. An alliance of three armed groups launched an offensive against the military in October and took control of Laukkaing, a key city on the border with China, last week.

China is concerned about the rising violence and the safety of Chinese citizens in northern Myanmar, where there is an active border trade between the two countries. China has also been cracking down on cyberscam operations that have trafficked Chinese workers into Myanmar and forced them to work, including in Laukkaing.

Mao said the military and the Three Brotherhood Alliance — which comprises the Myanmar National Democratic Alliance Army, the Ta'ang National Liberation Army and the Arakan Army — agreed to an immediate cease-fire, the disengaging of military personnel and the settlement of their disputes through negotiations.

"The two sides promised not to undermine the safety of Chinese people living in the border area and Chinese projects and personnel in Myanmar," she said. A previously reported cease-fire was not honored by either side.



PHOTO: RSS

In lack of piped water supply in his home area, a Chepang man fetches water from a distanced source by filling in plastic bottles in Kalika Municipality of Chitwan district.

West Virginia Senate oks bill to allow veterans to provide armed security in schools

AP
Charleston, W.Va., Jan. 12

County education boards in West Virginia could contract with military veterans and retired law enforcement officers to provide armed security at K-12 public schools under a bill passed Friday by the Republican-controlled state Senate.

Republican Sen. Eric Tarr of Putnam County said the bill was brought to him by retired military officers concerned about school shootings happening across the country.

Tarr, who chairs Senate Finance, said retired officers told him that "we need people in our schools who are trained to run at a gun at an instant when it's necessary to protect our children."

The bill passed unanimously with support from the 34-member body's three Democrats. Two Republicans were absent and didn't vote.

The legislation will now be considered by the House of Delegates.

The West Virginia Senate passed a similar bill last year, but it failed to advance in the House. A House committee passed a different bill last year that would allow K-12 teachers, administrators and support personnel with concealed carry permits to carry guns in schools, but it wasn't taken up again.

This year's Senate bill would allow county boards of education to contract with an honorably discharged veteran, former state trooper, former deputy sheriff or former federal law enforcement officer. The contractor would not be a school resource officer or considered law enforcement, nor would they have arrest power.

The contractor would need to have a concealed carry permit, pass a preemployment drug screening and have undergone physical, vision and psychiatric examinations. The bill also requires potential contractors to undergo training with the West Virginia State Police and complete a course on firearms and/or lethal use of force.

School boards wouldn't be permitted to hire a contractor convicted of domestic violence, driving under the influence or child abuse, among other criminal offenses.

Under the bill, any county board of education could contract with as many veterans or retired officers as it deems necessary. Republican Sen. Laura Wakim Chapman of Ohio County called the bill a crucial step toward making state public schools safer.

"Our teachers, our staff and our children deserve to go to school every day knowing that they will come home at night," she said.

Bird census in progress in Manohara area

RSS
Bhaktapur, Jan. 12

The counting of native and migratory birds has begun at Manohara area of Madhyapur Thimi Municipality-8 in Bhaktapur from Friday.

The bird census is organised by Wetland International in coordination with various organisations concerned with bird conservation including North Point Mall, Himalayan Nature and others.

As part of this census, the number of migratory as well as native birds in and around the local Manohara river will be counted, said Sanjaya Tha Shrestha of Thimi who has been conducting research and photography on birds.

It is said that 106 species of birds were recorded in the Manohara area in the last census. Eighty-six bird species were recorded. The Pied Whitter species was detected for the first time in the Kathmandu Valley in the census conducted last February.

The bird census is being carried out in various places of the country from January 2 to 18 and the census in Manohara is a part of this programme, it is said.

Winter storm with snow, ice, wind and bitter cold pummels much of the northern US

AP
St. Louis, Jan. 12

A massive winter storm swept the northern U.S. on Friday, with blinding snow in some places, freezing rain in others, and whipping winds and bitter cold temperatures across several states.

At least one death was suspected from the latest round of dangerous weather — a man was believed dead after an avalanche in the Idaho backcountry. Heavy snow and strong winds made driving virtually impossible in parts of Iowa, so much so that Republican presidential hopefuls called off campaign events. "Black ice" from freezing rain brought Kansas City, Missouri, to a standstill.

In Idaho, two men were rescued after being caught in the avalanche Thursday afternoon near the Montana border, but a third man was missing and presumed dead. The U.S. Air Force assisted in the search and rescue. Authorities weren't sure what the men were doing in the area that had been under an avalanche danger warning for several days.

Republican candidates campaigning ahead of Monday's Iowa caucuses were contending with a blizzard warning covering most of the state. Nikki Haley's campaign canceled three Friday events and said it would be hosting "telephone town halls." Ron DeSantis' campaign postponed events in Marshaltown and Clear Lake.

The Iowa Department of Transportation's road conditions map on Friday showed that virtually every major highway and interstate was partially or completely covered. The agency said driver visibility was "near zero" in some places, and wind-fueled drifts were quickly erasing the work of plow drivers.

The Iowa State Patrol posted photos of an icy wreck. "Please, don't put yourself or others in danger," the agency wrote. "The road conditions are extremely dangerous!"

Blizzard warnings were issued in some places, including southwestern Minnesota and the Green Bay area of Wisconsin. Forecasts for the Milwaukee area predicted heavy snow stretching into Saturday morning with wind gusts up to 40 mph (64 kph).

Snow wasn't the only problem.

In Kansas City, Missouri, "black ice" caused dozens of wrecks as freezing rain created any icy sheen over the roads. Temperatures in the mid-teens combined with wind of more than 20 mph (32 kph) created a bitterly cold wind chill of around 9 below zero Fahrenheit (minus 23 degrees Celsius).

The cold was the biggest concern in the Dakotas. It was 11 degrees below zero F (minus 24 degrees C) in Bismarck, North Dakota, on Friday morning, and forecasters warned the weekend will get even worse. It could reach 20 below F (minus 29 degrees C) by early Sunday.

Buffalo supermarket gunman who killed 10 will face the death penalty

AP
Buffalo, Jan. 12

Federal prosecutors will seek the death penalty against a white supremacist who killed 10 Black people at a Buffalo supermarket, they said in a court filing Friday.

Payton Gendron, 20, is already serving a sentence of life in prison with no chance of parole after he pleaded guilty to state charges of murder and hate-motivated domestic terrorism in the 2022 attack. New York does not have capital punishment, but the Justice Department had the option of seeking the death penalty in a separate federal hate crimes case. Gendron had promised to plead guilty in that case if prosecutors agreed not to seek the death penalty.

There was no immediate comment from the victims' families or prosecutors.

The Justice Department has made federal death penalty cases a rarity since the election of President Joe Biden, a Democrat who opposes capital punishment. Attorney General Merrick Garland instituted a moratorium on federal executions in 2021 pending a review of procedures. Although the moratorium does not prevent prosecutors from seeking death sentences, the Justice Department has done so sparingly.

It successfully sought the death penalty for a antisemitic gunman who murdered 11 people at a Pittsburgh synagogue. It also went ahead last year with an effort to get the death sentence against an Islamic extremist who killed eight people on a New York City bike path, though a lack of a unanimous jury meant that prosecution resulted in a life sentence.

The Justice Department has declined to pursue the death penalty in other mass killings. It passed on seeking the execution of a gunman who killed 23 people at a Walmart in El Paso, Texas.

Relatives of the victims in Buffalo have expressed mixed views on whether they think federal prosecutors should pursue the death penalty in that case.

On May 14, 2022, Gendron attacked shoppers and workers with a semi-automatic rifle at a Tops Friendly Market in Buffalo after driving more than 200 miles (320 kilometers) from his home in rural Conklin, New York.

Nepal's UN envoy elected to...

Committee from the regular second meeting of the year 2024 to the regular first meeting of the year 2025.

Primarily a rule-making organisation, the WTO deliberations are more focused on trade and development matters in recent years. Ambassador Subedi will have the opportunity to coordinate WTO Members and bring them together to harness the trade and development opportunities within the framework of the Marrakesh Agreement.

The Mission said in the statement that the appointment of Ambassador Subedi as the Chairperson of the Committee offers an opportunity for Nepal not only to facilitate deliberation on trade and development among the WTO Members but also to engage in dialogue with other larger stakeholders of the trade and investment field including development partners.

In addition, this role becomes instrumental in coordinating all stakeholders in line with Doha Action Plan, in mobilising and mainstreaming the aid for trade for the benefit of the Least Developed Countries (LDCs), facilitating the discussions on the LDCs' matters in other WTO bodies, create a conducive environment for those LDCs on the path to graduate.

This role is timely and befitting as Nepal prepares to graduate from the LDC category in the year 2026, read the statement.

Pet walkers now face KMC....

According to Section 5 of the Kathmandu Metropolitan Dog/Cat Sterilization, Vaccination and Documentation Working Procedure, 2023, pet owners can be fined up to Rs. 5,000 if their dogs/cats are found loose and excreting in a public place, other's yards or prohibited areas.

According to the KMC, it has mobilised city police to make the campaign successful. Upon receiving complaints, they will gather evidence through CCTV footage and by asking people. Based on the evidence, appropriate actions will be taken.

Dr. Jha informed that the KMC would start microchipping animals for records starting from mid-January. He informed that pet owners could easily get their pets microchipped by a veterinarian certified by the KMC, facilitating easy access to animal records at the ward and municipal levels.

Meanwhile, the KMC had also launched a sterilisation campaign to control the population of community dogs and cats aiming to permanently sterilise 5,800 street animals including dogs, cats and cattle and vaccinate 16,000 against rabies by mid-April 2024.

According to the Agriculture and Animal Husbandry Department, the metropolis had already permanently sterilised more than 4,300 street animals in the past two months.

Dr. Jha informed that they paused the campaign for a month due to cold weather and were now targeting to achieve their goal within a month after resuming it because nine different organisations were active in the campaign throughout 32 wards of the metropolis.

National Unity Day marked...

where the Rastriya Prajatantra Party held a tea reception, RPP chair Rajendra Lingden and other senior leaders of the party laid the wreath at the statute of Prithvi Narayan Shah in front of Singha Durbar.

The RPP organised a rally from Bhrikutimandap. At the tea reception, Rastriya Swatantra Party President Rabi Lamichhane, leaders of various political parties, security officials, former administrators and others were also present.

RPP Chairman Rajendra Lingden and other party leaders welcomed the distinguished guests.

Talking with journalists, Oli said that celebrating National Unity Day was good work. He thanked RPP for hosting the tea reception.

Rastriya Swatantra Party chair Rabi Lamichhane said it was not necessary to be narrow-minded to show respect to King Prithvi Narayan Shah.

He said all should respect to nationally proud late King Prithvi Narayan Shah who unified the nation.

Lingden said Prithivi Jayanti Day was celebrated in all districts.

He said this year the day was celebrated widely in comparison to last year and he thanked all the participants.

He said the issue raised by his party was not specific to a particular party, it was linked with national unity and other parties accepted it.

Cold wave affects life across...

and the Nepali Army have arranged firewood to make fire for the common people in some places.

Chief District Officer and Coordinator of the District Disaster Management Committee in Banke Shrawan Kumar Pokharel said, "We have urged the local levels to make necessary arrangements in their respective municipalities to save citizens from cold."

Over the past three days, numerous morning and evening flights to and from Nepalgunj have been cancelled owing to dense fog and lack of visibility. The Civil Aviation Office in Nepalgunj reported that a significant number of morning air flights to hilly districts such as Humla, Bajura, Muguko Rara, Dolpa, and Jumla are being cancelled, with some enduring delays.

According to Suresh Khanal, the head of the Civil Aviation Office in Nepalgunj, both morning and evening flights to Kathmandu, along with those to the hilly districts, are facing disruptions.

The temperature in Nepalgunj has been falling over the last four days. On Thursday and Friday, the temperature dropped even further, ranging from 7.7 to 9 degrees Celsius, the field office of the Department of Hydrology and Meteorology at Ranjha informed.

Meanwhile, our correspondent from Dhanusha Bijay Kumar Sah reported that people in Dhanusha have been grappling with extreme cold for the past few days.

Gulam Sada, 60, at Musahari village of Mithila Municipality-4 in the district, is feeling unwell due to the cold weather. He used to support his family through agricultural labour in the village but lost his job with the drop in temperature. Daily wage earners are finding it difficult to support their families because they are losing jobs because of cold.

Sada, with a family of seven, including five children, is struggling in the extreme cold. They lack warm clothing and are relying on fire to keep them warm. Sleeping on straw beds with straw-filled blankets, their hardship is intensified as they lack enough food and clothes to keep themselves warm.

Gangaram Sada, 45, of the same Musahar village, expressed that fire was the only option to combat the cold. With no warm clothes at home, he shared that cold had added tremendous challenges in their day-to-day life.

Gangaram, with a family of six, talked about the shivering nights caused by bone-chilling cold and their lack of preparedness because of their poverty, which has made their life extremely difficult. He expressed frustration, stating, "My earnings are not sufficient for both food and amenities like proper beds and blankets. For us, straw beds are our actual beds, and blankets remain a luxury we cannot afford, and my children are suffering."

The Province government to distribute 20,000 blankets

Meanwhile, the Madhes government has planned to distribute blankets to 20,000 people affected by the cold wave. Mohammad Samim, Minister of Home Communications and Law, said that preparations are underway after collecting data on those in need.

The provincial government aims to coordinate with security agencies and utilise the Provincial Disaster Management Committee's statistics to facilitate the blanket distribution. Minister Samim emphasised the government's commitment to collaborating with various entities involved in disaster management and risk reduction to save people in extreme cold.

ISRAEL DEFENDS ITSELF AT THE UN'S COURT AGAINST ALLEGATIONS OF GENOCIDE

AP
The Hague, Netherlands, Jan. 12

Accused of committing genocide against Palestinians, Israel insisted at the United Nations' highest court Friday that its war in Gaza was a legitimate defense of its people and said that it was Hamas militants who were guilty of genocide.

Israel described the allegations leveled by South Africa as hypocritical and said that one of the biggest cases ever to come before an international court reflected a world turned upside down. Israeli leaders defend their air and ground offensive in Gaza as a legitimate response to Hamas' Oct. 7 attack, when militants stormed through Israeli communities, killed some 1,200 people and took around 250 hostage.

Israeli legal advisor Tal Becker told a packed auditorium at the ornate Palace of Peace in The Hague that the country is fighting a "war it did not start and did not want."

"In these circumstances, there can hardly be a charge more false and more malevolent than the allegation against Israel of genocide," he added, noting that the horrible suffering of civilians in war was not enough to level that charge.

Film-related bill will be tabled in upcoming Parliament session: Minister Sharma



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 12

The Minister of Communication and Information Technology, Rekha Sharma has said that she was ready to table a bill related to films in the upcoming session of the Parliament.

During an interaction programme organised by the Ministry of Communication and Information Technology and Film Censor Board in Lalitpur on Friday, Minister Sharma said that the bill would be prepared and presented to Parliament based on the suggestions received to address the issues faced by film workers. She also requested further input from stakeholders in the programme.

At the same time, Minister Sharma emphasised the need to focus on the quality of Nepali films, as they must compete with foreign films, so they need to enhance the quality of both form and content of the films.

Minister Sharma stressed that Nepali films should be capable of competing with foreign counterparts.

"We have sent a letter to the Ministry of Finance and Law seeking in-principle approval for the Motion Picture Bill.

The approval is expected soon, and the convention we are planning is set to begin around February 1 or 3. We are diligently preparing and submitting this film law to the parliamentary session," said Minister Sharma.

The law will play a significant role in shaping Nepal's film industry. The quality of Nepali movies needs to be upgraded to compete with foreign films, she added.

Stating that currently, foreign films are being released in Nepali cinema theatres while Nepali films do not get theatres, Minister Sharma said discussions are essential to address these issues.

She said that the government should also focus on what is beneficial for the promotion of local films and emphasised the government's responsibility to promote domestic films.

Australian issue of Pratik magazine launched

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 12



The special Australian issue of Pratik magazine, titled 'Fire and Rain,' was launched amid a programme held in Kathmandu recently. Australian Ambassador to Nepal, Felicity Volk, and the editor of the magazine, poet Yuyutsu Sharma, jointly unveiled the special Australian issue.

Speaking about the Australian special issue, Yuyutsu Sharma said that he has collected poems, articles, and art from Australian writers and creators. This marks the first such issue about Australia in Pratik Magazine, he added.

Australian Ambassador to Nepal, Felicity Volk, said that the magazine had made a significant contribution to strengthening the bilateral relationship between Nepal and Australia. She emphasised that diplomacy often focuses on economic policy and foreign policy, however, cultural voices presented in Pratik can play a crucial role in strengthening cultural ties between Nepal and Australia.

The Ambassador noted that Australian writers discuss universal themes, providing an important way to foster common understanding, compassion, and a shared humanity.

The magazine comprises 15 poems, eight fiction and non-fiction writing, an interview with Ambassador Felicity Volk, and references to the top five poetry books and novels from Australia by Jennifer Mackenzie and Sally Breen, respectively.

Yuddha Prasad Mishra's 117th birth anniversary marked



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 12

Progressive Nepali poet Yuddha Prasad Mishra's 117th birth anniversary was observed in Kathmandu on Friday.

Madhav Pradhan and Jitendra Prasad Chaudhary sang the progressive song titled 'Rakta Krantiko Jwalamukhi' of poet Mishra amid a programme.

Speaking at the programme, Professor Jibendra Dev Giri talked about Mishra's contribution to the progressive poem and the development of Nepali literature, song and music.

In the programme poets including Triratna Shakya, Laxmi Thapa, Rameshwor Neupane and Lila Lekali recited their poems.

Born in 1964 BS at Somlingtar of Bhaktapur district, Mishra started writing poems in his early teens.

He died in 2047 BS.

NDA DANCE DIRECTOR AWARD HELD

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 12



The first 'NDA Dance Director Award – 2080' took place for the first time in Nepal at Rastriya Naach Ghar in Jamal, Kathmandu recently. The event featured awards in 24 dance categories, with director Navina KC earning the accolade for the best folk dance from the Rai community.

Bhairav Bahadur Thapa, Nepal's pioneering dance director and dance emperor, expressed that such programmes would be very fruitful in boosting the morale of dance directors.



'Annapoorani: The Goddess of Food' removed from Netflix

AGENCIES
New Delhi, Jan. 12

The movie 'Annapoorani: The Goddess of Food,' featuring actress Nayanthara, has become embroiled in controversy over accusations of offending religious sentiments. After its theatrical release on December 1 and subsequent availability on the streaming platform Netflix from December 29, the film faced legal action in the form of an FIR.

Following the complaint, Netflix has removed 'Annapoorani' from its platform. Zee Studios, one of the producers of the film, has issued a statement addressing the concerns of the protesters. They wrote to the Vishwa Hindu Parishad, stating that the film will be removed from the OTT platform until edited.

For those unfamiliar with the situation, Ramesh Solanki, founder of the Hindu IT cell, filed a complaint against the film, claiming that it is 'offending Hindu religious sentiments.' The complaint was filed against Nayanthara, Jai, writer-director Nilesh Krishna, producers Jatin Sethi, R Ravindran, and Punit Goenka, Zee Studios Chief Business Officer Shariq Patel, and the head of Netflix India, Monika Shergill.

In the complaint, Solanki mentioned that 'Annapoorani' was promoting 'love jihad.' A scene in the film created a huge uproar. In the scene in question, Jai's character, Farhan, convinces the heroine to consume meat by explaining that Lord Rama has also eaten meat. In the climax scene of the film, Nayanthara's character, Annapoorani, wears a hijab and offers namaz before making biryani in the final round of a cooking competition.

'Annapoorani' revolves around the story of a Brahmin woman who is very ambitious. She wants to explore her passion for cooking but gets stuck to the orthodox ideals that she has been taught by her conservative family since childhood. She doesn't let her caste and religious differences come in her way and aims to fulfill her dreams.

'Annapoorani' is directed by debutant filmmaker Nilesh Krishnaa. It also stars Sathiyama, Achyuth Kumar, KS Ravikumar, Karthik Kumar, and Renuka, among others.

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

ARIES: You're taking control of your life -- and others can see it! You may have gone through a period where it felt like every day brought a new problem, but you're finally able to find a rhythm that works for you.

TAURUS: You don't have to be a boxer to fight back! If someone is spreading unfair rumors about you or refusing to give you the credit that you deserve, then it's time to stand up for yourself.

GEMINI: Someone may be pushing you to act out of character. You know who you are inside, but there could be people around you who are trying to get you to show a nastier side of yourself.

CANCER: You might be competing against many other people throughout the day. Regardless of your typical attitude toward competition, when it comes to something that you really want.

LEO: You can let your hard work do the talking at the moment. A superior or an authority figure may begin questioning you, but you'd be wise to let your record speak for itself.

VIRGO: Who you are is enough, Virgo. You may currently base much of your worth on winning or reaching a certain standard that you set for yourself. Unfortunately, this can become stressful if you fall short of the standards.

LIBRA: Someone in your life potentially understands your needs -- whether you've known them for years or just met. Keep your eyes peeled for a business partner or advisor.

SCORPIO: You're a person that others can count on. There may be a call to action that comes for you during the day, either to serve people that you know personally or to assist the community at large.

SAGITTARIUS: Your dedication may beat out the talent of someone else. No matter how naturally gifted they are, you may have been more faithful to studying or practicing your skills.

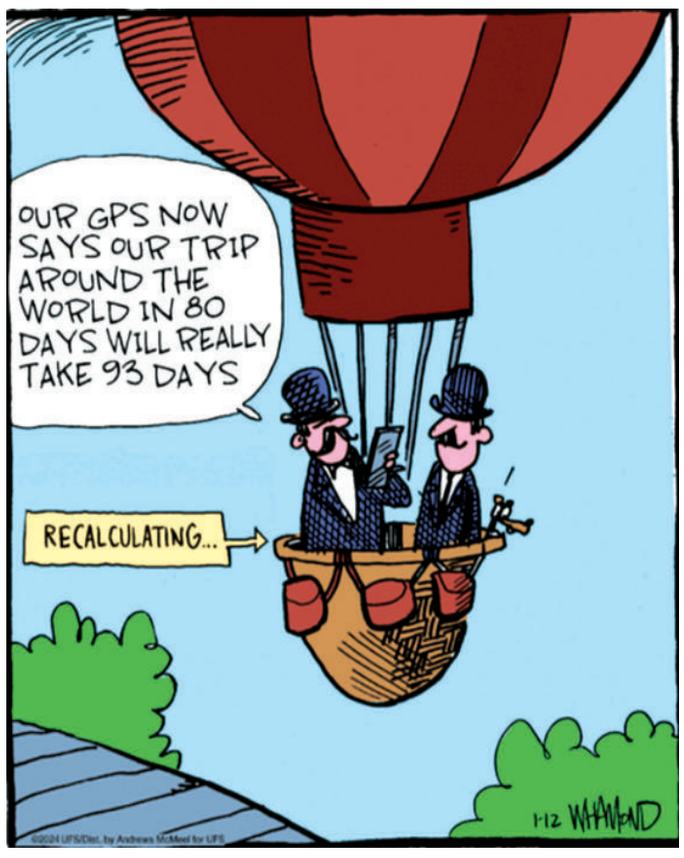
CAPRICORN: Creativity is calling, Capricorn! You may have a bit of extra time to yourself at present, either for a vacation or just a day to rest. Either way, this means you have more freedom to follow your heart!

AQUARIUS: You might not want to contend with those who are trying to compete with you. While you're likely just expressing yourself the only way that you know how.

PISCES: You might find yourself competing for someone's time and attention. There may be multiple people trying to catch the eye of this person for one reason or another.

CARTOON

gocomics.com





PM Cup Men's National Cricket kicks off today among 10 teams

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 12

The PM Cup Men's National Cricket Tournament is starting on Saturday across three venues, including one outside the Kathmandu Valley, between 10 teams.

Other than the Kathmandu-based Tribhuvan University Cricket Ground and Mulpani International Cricket Ground, Bhairahawa Cricket Ground in Rupandehi district will be hosting the tournament participated by seven provincial teams and three departmental teams.

The opening day will see the matches between Bagmati and Nepal Police, Koshi and Madhes, and Lumbini and Gandaki at TU Cricket Ground, Mulpani Cricket Ground and Bhairahawa Cricket Ground respectively.

The provincial teams conducted district-level competitions to select players for a 14-men team to represent the respective province. More than half of the teams participating in the tournament have also revealed their squads.

Moreover, provincial teams lacked national-level players as the majority of them have been tied up with the three departmental teams – Nepal Police, APF and Nepali Army.

Nevertheless, only Nepal Police had announced their squads until Friday evening; APF's captain and coach have only been disclosed.

Men's national team captain Rohit Paudel has returned to captain the APF team in the tournament with former national cricketer Gyanendra Malla as the coach. Paudel was in APF's squad in 2018, he then moved to Army. Other members of the squad have not been disclosed publicly yet.

On the other hand, Dipendra Singh Airee is captaining the squad of Nepal Police being coached by Manjit Shrestha. Aarif Sheikh, Karan KC, Kushal Bhurtel, Arjun Saud, Dilip Nath, Amit Shrestha, Sunil Dhamala, Lalit Rajbanshi, Sagar Dhakal, Shankar Rana, Rashid Khan, Lalit Bhandari and Roshand Budhal are in Police's team.

Similarly, five provincial teams made public their squads until Friday evening.

Ankit Subedi is captaining the team of Koshi Province coached by Pushpa Thapa. Koshi's players include Phirdos Ansari, Sonu Ansari, Minas Thapa, Ice Bhattarai, Sujan Thapaliya, Suman Gahatraj, Samir Karki, Sonu Mandal, Kamal Khatri, Heman Rai, Bhupal Luitel, Abhiyas Timsina, Saujan Ghimire. Dipak Raj Joshi, Bhupal Dangol, Saugat Bhattarai and Aswin Kamat are in reserve.

Madhes Province has decided to allow Hari Shankar Sah to lead the provincial squad with Sunil Sah as the coach. Other players in the team are Niraj Yadav, Anil Kumar Sah, Pawan Sarraf, Abhishek Tiwari, Arniko Yadav, Rahul Mandal, Bishal Patel, Ranjit Kumar, Rupesh Singh, Samsad Ansari, Pradip Paswan and Rajesh Yadav. Dablu Malik, Bhulwan Sahani, Parthiv Yadav and Sahil Patel are in reserve.

As per the Bagmati Province Cricket Association, Rit Gautam is captaining the side with Kalam Ali as the coach. Bagmati's teams comprise of Aashutosh Ghiraiya, Ishan Pandey, Rabin Joshi, Bibek Rana Magar, Pratik Shrestha, Pratish GC, Surya Tamang, Krijan Gurung, Rijan Dhakal, Gautam KC, Ashok Paudel, Sonu Devkota and Bipin Acharya. Sandesh Karki, Gaurav Khadka, Dipesh Shrestha and Krish Karki are in reerve.

Gandaki Province Cricket Association gave the captaincy of the team being coached by Rijan Prajoo to Bipin Khatri. With Sameer Kandel as the vice-captain, Ishwor Chhetri, Muskan Thapa Magar, Roshan Gautam, Krish Ayer, Ashwini Rana Magar, Kamal Pariyar, Amrit Gurung, Krishna Poudel, Karan Pangeni, Sandeep Parajuli, Chandrakanta Poudel and Ankit Neupane. Arjun Rayamajhi, Dinesh Budha Magar, Govinda BK and Tulsiram Bhandari are in reserve.

Lumbini Province Cricket Association has also made public a 14-men squad after concerns from Banke Cricket Association. Banke Cricket Association, on January 8, had shown reservations to the list of players called for closed camp citing only three of its players were selected for the provincial team despite the district winning the selection tournament.

Nevertheless, Lumbini's team was disclosed on Friday. As per Lumbini Province Cricket Association, Sushant Singh Thapa of Banke is captaining its side with Basant Shahi as the coach. Other players in the team are Prajwal Bahadur Thapa, Birat Bhandari, Krishna Karki, Samrat Bhusal, Mrinal Gurung, Dilsad Ali, Nar Bahadur Sarki, Nirmal Gurung, Rahul Chauhan, Abhisekh Gautam, Mohammad Hussain, Bir Bahadur Gharti Magar and Ikhlaque Ahmad. Bishnu Katariya, Rupesh Bashyal, Mohan Khatri and Hemant Acharya are in reserve.

Karnali announced its 20-men team for closed camp on January 4. The team's main squad was not announced until 6:30 pm on Friday. There was also no update regarding the team of Sudurpahschim Province.

Teenage Grand Slam champion Coco Gauff entering Australia Open without pressure



PHOTO: AP
Coco Gauff reacts during a press conference ahead of the Australian Open tennis championships at Melbourne Park, Friday, Jan. 12, 2024.

AP
Melbourne, Jan. 12

Now that the pressure to win a Grand Slam singles title as a teenager is over, Coco Gauff feels liberated enough to discuss her next target: a career tally in double digits.

She's entering the Australian Open as a reigning Grand Slam champion, new territory for the 19-year-old American. Had she not fulfilled those expectations at last year's U.S. Open, this would have been her last shot at being a teenage major winner.

Gauff, who turns 20 in March, believes she can play with more freedom now in pursuit of a second major title as the No. 4 seeded player at Melbourne Park.

The tournament starts on Sunday, a day earlier than usual.

Defending champion Novak Djokovic, aiming for a recording-extending 11th Australian title and 25th overall, announced ahead of the schedule's release that he'd be playing Sunday night. Djokovic opens against 18-year-old qualifier Dino Prizmic of Croatia.

Gauff's first-round match is against Anna Karolina Schmeiedlova, a 29-year-old from Slovakia who has only been past the third round once in 35 majors.

Having rebounded from a shocking first-round exit at Wimbledon to winning a breakthrough major title at the very next major in New York has helped with a shift in mindset.

"I think I put too much pressure on winning a Slam. I think I was feeling like I have to do it," Gauff said. "When I went on the scene at 15, I felt like I had to win a Slam as a teenager because that's what everybody thought.

"Honestly, going into the U.S. Open, I didn't expect it. I felt like I was having a bad season, and my focus was just to get through the season and focus on the Australian Open this year."

It was the loss at Wimbledon that helped her take pause, relax and think about all those rounds before the final, one by one. She'd thought losing in the first round would have been the worst thing to happen to her.

Turns out, "wasn't even that bad," she said. "The world didn't end. The sun still shines. I still have my friends and family.

Gauff is in the same quarter of the draw as four-time major winner Naomi Osaka and Caroline Wozniacki, both past Australian Open champions who are returning to Melbourne Park as mothers for the first time.

On the other side of the draw, No. 1-ranked Iga Swiatek is in a tough section, starting with an opener against 2020 Australian Open champion Sofia Kenin. Their only previous meeting was at the 2020 French Open when Swiatek beat Kenin in the final.

On the men's side, Djokovic has long dominated Melbourne Park. He's on a 28-match winning streak here — 21 before and seven after the tournament he was forced to miss in 2022 because he wasn't vaccinated for COVID-19.

He's the only one of the so-called Big Three in the field after 22-time major winner Rafael Nadal withdrew last week, his comeback from a year-long injury layoff lasting just three matches.

Djokovic is establishing new rivalries now, some with much younger players such as 20-year-old Carlos Alcaraz, who beat him in the Wimbledon final, and No. 4 Jannik Sinner, the 22-year-old Italian who beat him twice in a month late last season in the round-robin stage of the ATP Finals and at the Davis Cup.

SNIPPETS

PM says govt serious on improving sports sector

Kathmandu (TRN): Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has said that the government was serious towards the sports sector's improvement. Addressing the opening of the two-day National Wado-Ryu Open Karate Championship on Friday, PM Prachanda said that sports had several importance and demanded proper development. He also stressed that it was the first time in the country's history that the sports sector saw a massive development in a short time. "Under my initiation, around two months ago, Lower Mulpani Stadium, Girija Prasad Koirala Cricket Stadium and Gautam Buddha International Cricket Stadium have been enlisted as pride projects and will be constructed soon," said PM Prachanda. The Karate competition is being held at Yeti Party Palace in Basundhara between the champions of the province-level competitions.

Lehecka through to Adelaide Int'l final, Mertens does same at Hobart

Adelaide (AP): Jiri Lehecka defeated third-seeded Sebastian Korda 6-2, 6-1 on Friday to advance to the Adelaide International final. The Czech player, who has dropped only one set in the tournament, will face either Alexander Bublik or Jack Draper in Saturday's final at Memorial Drive. Bublik and Draper were scheduled to play a night semifinal. In the WTA portion of the tournament, sixth-seeded and 2017 French Open champion Jelena Ostapenko beat Ekaterina Alexandrova 6-2, 7-6 (3). Ostapenko will play the winner of the night semifinal between Daria Kasatkina and Jessica Pegula. Meanwhile, top-seeded Elise Mertens advanced to the final of the Hobart International with a 6-4, 4-6, 7-5 win over Daria Saville. Mertens broke Saville's serve in the 11th game of the final set and held her service in the next game for the win. Mertens will play either Emma Navarro or Yuan Yue in Saturday's final. Navarro and Yuan played their semifinal later Friday.

Newcastle's Joelinton to miss at least six weeks with thigh injury

Newcastle (AP): Newcastle midfielder Joelinton will be sidelined until at least late February because of a thigh injury in what manager Eddie Howe described as a "big blow" to the team. The 27-year-old Brazil international damaged a tendon during Newcastle's 3-0 win at Sunderland last Saturday in the FA Cup, the Premier League club said Friday. Howe described Joelinton as the "driving force" of the midfield and said the player would be out for at least six weeks. The Brazilian has scored three goals in 22 total appearances this season for ninth-place Newcastle, which hosts Manchester City on Saturday. Howe's team has lost three straight league games.

Barcelona facing Real Madrid for second straight year in Spanish Super Cup final

AP
Riyadh, Jan. 12

The "clasico" will decide the Spanish Super Cup winner for the second straight season.

Barcelona defeated Osasuna 2-0 on Thursday to set up a rematch of last year's final against Real Madrid in Saudi Arabia.

Robert Lewandowski and Lamine Yamal scored a goal each for the Catalan club, which last season won the title for its first trophy with coach Xavi Hernández and without Lionel Messi.

Madrid reached Sunday's final by defeating rival Atletico Madrid 5-3 in extra time on Wednesday. It won the first "clasico" of the season 2-1 in the Spanish league in October in Barcelona.

Barcelona beat Madrid 3-1 to lift the trophy last season, and another triumph this year would come in handy for the Catalan club as it arrived under pressure after a series of lacklustre performances. It sits seven points behind Spanish league leaders Madrid and Girona at the competition's halfway point.

Barcelona hadn't won by more than one goal in 20 matches, since a 5-0 rout of Antwerp in the group stage of the Champions League in September. The only other time it won by two goals or more this season was in a 2-0 triumph against Cadiz in the Spanish league in August.

"We've been improving," Barcelona midfielder Frenkie de Jong said. "The first half wasn't too good but we played better in the second. To play against Madrid is always exciting. It will be a match between two high-level teams. We'll be ready."

Barcelona qualified for the Super Cup as the Spanish league champion a year ago. Osasuna qualified by making it to the Copa del Rey final last season, when it lost to Madrid.

The Super Cup marks the first Spanish competition in which the audios between officials during video reviews are made available after matches. The procedure will continue during Spanish league matches.



PHOTO: AP
Barcelona's Raphinha fights for the ball with Osasuna player during the Spanish Super Cup semifinal at Al Awal Park Stadium in Riyadh, Saudi Arabia, Thursday.

New Zealand starts T20 series beating Pakistan by 46 runs



AP
Auckland, Jan. 12

Daryl Mitchell and Kane Williamson made brisk half-centuries to propel New Zealand to a 46-run win over Pakistan on Saturday in the first of five Twenty20 internationals.

PHOTO: BLACKCAPS' FACEBOOK
Kane Williamson celebrates after scoring a half-century against Pakistan in the match of a T20 series at Eden Park in Auckland on Friday.

Mitchell blasted 61 from 27 balls, following Williamson who scored 57 from 42 as New Zealand made 226-8 after being sent in, the highest-ever total against Pakistan in a T20 international. Williamson was twice dropped, on nine by Babar from the bowling of Abbas Afridi and on 39 by Iftikhar Ahmed off Usama Mir.

New Zealand piled on runs through the middle of its innings — 80 between the eighth and 14th overs — but didn't finish quite as strongly at it would have hoped. Glenn Phillips made 19 runs from 11 balls and Mark Chapman 26 from 11 at the death. But New Zealand may have been a batter short in the absence of Mitch Santner who was ruled out of the match at the last moment after testing positive for the coronavirus.

Tim Southee took 4-25 for New Zealand to become the first bowler from any nation to claim 150 wickets in T20 internationals.

Saim Ayub gave Pakistan an explosive start to its innings when he hit 27 from eight balls with three sixes and two fours. But he was immensely unlucky to be run out backing up too far.

Mohammad Rizwan fell before the end of the power play, top edging a ball from Tim Southee which hung for a long time in the night sky before being caught by Conway, the New Zealand wicketkeeper.

As Pakistan's set batsman, Babar was crucial but New Zealand did well to limit him by bowling shorter to restrict his access to the shorter straight boundaries at Eden Park.

Babar fell at the start of the 17th over and with him went Pakistan's last hopes.

WEATHER

Saturday

Sunrise at 6:56 am, Sunset at 5:29 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Saturday)

Partly cloudy in Gandaki Province, Lumbini Province, Karnali Province and Sudur Pashchim Province along with the hilly regions of Karnali Province and mainly fair in the rest of the country.

Expected Temp.: 16 - 18°C
Rain Probability: ...%

Friday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dadeldhura	17.8	4.8	0.0
Dipayal	22.7	3.8	0.0
Dhangadi	12.4	9.5	0.0
Birendranagar	20.5	3.0	0.0
Nepalgunj	13.8	10.0	0.0
Jumla	20.0	-5.3	0.0
Ghorahi	19.3	7.7	0.0
Pokhara	19.5	8.0	0.0
Bhairahawa	14.4	8.0	0.0
Simara	17.3	9.5	0.0
Kathmandu	18.0	5.0	0.0
Okhaldhunga	16.3	7.5	0.0
Taplejung	17.6	7.2	0.0
Dhankuta	23.0	8.0	0.0
Biratnagar	21.4	11.8	0.0
Jomsom	15.0	-1.0	0.0*
Dharan	21.4	10.0	0.0*
Lumle	16.0	6.0	0.0*
Janakpur	23.0	11.6	0.0*
Jiri	15.2	0.7	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

January 13, 2024

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.38	Rs. 132.98
Euro	1	Rs. 145.01	Rs. 145.67
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 168.69	Rs. 169.45
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 155.05	Rs. 155.75
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 88.56	Rs. 88.96
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 99.02	Rs. 99.47
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 99.41	Rs. 99.86
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 9.12	Rs. 9.16
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.47	Rs. 18.55
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.30	Rs. 35.46
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.29	Rs. 36.46
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.77	Rs. 3.79
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.04	Rs. 36.21
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 28.48	Rs. 28.61
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 10.07	Rs. 10.12
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 12.87	Rs. 12.93
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.45	Rs. 19.53
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 16.92	Rs. 17.00
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 430.77	Rs. 432.72
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 351.14	Rs. 352.73

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

Published by Executive Chairman **Bishnu Prasad Subedi** and General Manager **Lal Bahadur Airi** for the Gorkhapatra Corporation • Printed at G.S. Press, Kathmandu • Acting Editor-in-Chief: **Bhimsen Thapaliya**
Phone: Editorial 5322279 • Advertisement 5327493, 5331394 • Distribution 5320638 • E-mail: mgorkhapatra@gmail.com, trnfeatures@hotmail.com • Registered No. 29/028/022 • G.P.O. 30/053/54